



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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BOUND VOLUMES of the Official Report (each with a comprehensive Index) are issued periodically during the Session. There is no fixed subscription rate, but prices will be quoted on each publication.

*Published by Office of Chamber Reporting,
Parliament House, Accra.*

*Designed and Printed by Publishing Department,
Parliament House, Accra.*

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

THIRD MEETING, 2025

Friday, 19th December, 2025

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 12:50 p.m.*

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE
CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday, 18th December, 2025 under correction.

[No correction was made to the Votes and Proceedings of Thursday, 18th December, 2025]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the *Official Report* of Tuesday, 9th December, 2025 for your correction.

[No correction was made to the Official Report of Tuesday, 9th December, 2025]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the agreement is to take the item numbered 8, at the commencement of public Business, Presentation of Papers.

Majority Leadership, any contrary indication?

Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor): Mr Speaker, there is no contrary position, so proceed to take the item numbered 8 as agreed.

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, is the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources properly constituted to take the item and has he done the necessary consultation?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, you are free to engage the Minister.

Yes, Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, the item numbered 8?

PAPERS

By the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources —

Mining Lease Agreement Between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources) and Barari DV Ghana Limited for the mining of Lithium and other minerals at Mankessim (42.63km²) in the Mfantseman Municipality in the Central Region.

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah: Mr Speaker, I want to find out from the Hon Minister whether he is relaying the withdrawn agreement. He came here and withdrew this Agreement. He is back with it and did not tell us anything. So, I am invoking the rules. Standing Order 97(3). Yes, I am invoking it. He should tell us something about it. He should let Ghanaians know that he is relaying the Agreement he withdrew and whether he is retaining the 10 per cent royalty. What is he talking about?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Agreement has been duly presented. It is referred to the Committee on Lands and Natural Resources for consideration and report.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we are minded to move smoothly and to reduce the load of work so that we can rise on time. I see the Majority Chief Whip and the Leader himself is here. What is the plan? Let us know what the plan is so that we can—So, should we move to Appropriation? Are you ready for appropriation? Majority Chief Whip, do you have any Papers you are going to lay again?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: So, where are your Papers?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, there is one more Instrument to lay. So, we will do an *Addendum*. But in the meantime, we would proceed to take the Consideration of the Appropriation Bill, 2025. Please, Hon Patrick Yaw Boamah, address the Chair if you are minded.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, as you engage, permit me to acknowledge the presence of students from God is Able Academy, led by Samuel Bekoe, the headteacher. They are from Amasaman. They are 52 in number.

[Students from God is Able Academy were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We also have Abokobi Presby 1 Basic School, led by Isaac Mensah Martey, a teacher. They are from Dome Kwabenya and they are 70 in number.

[Students from Abokobi Presby 1 Basic School were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, on your behalf, I welcome them to Parliament of Ghana. May you kindly resume your seats. I wish you a fruitful visit to Parliament.

Hon Members, I will not refer to that as an attack. It is a privileged contact. That is a privileged contact, not an attack.

Yes, Hon Habib Iddrisu?

1:00 p.m.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, now that we have the Hon Minister for Finance here, we need the attention of the Hon Minister for Finance, and he is pressing his phone

Mr Speaker, the Hon Deputy Minister for Finance has been able to do a very good negotiation this morning, and now that his boss, the Hon Minister, is here, we are ready for the Appropriation Bill except that I want to find out from the Hon Majority Chief Whip the number of *Addendums* he intends to have today because yesterday, he had four *Addendums*. So, we need to know how many he intends to bring today. However, we can move into the Consideration Stage of the Appropriation Bill. He should give us a full disclosure. We do not want him to give us over 10 or 15 *Addendums* because we are rising *sine die* today.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, yes, we would not exceed three *Addendums*.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, whether or not it will be three, four or five, only God knows. We are here to work for Mother Ghana, so it does not matter the number of *Addendum* papers that will come before us.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I pray that we take the item numbered 21 on the *Order Paper*. My Brother, the Hon

Minority Chief Whip, is not opposed at all.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Appropriation (No. 2) Bill, 2025, at Consideration Stage.

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE

The Appropriation (No. 2) Bill, 2025

Clause 1 to 5 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

First Schedule ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Second Schedule — Retain internally generated fund breakdown.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairman of the Committee, any advertised amendment?

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, there is no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Hon Members, any proposed amendment to the Second Schedule?

Yes, Alhaji Habib.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, on the Second Schedule, the money for the Ministry for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, is inadequate. There are a lot of service providers under this Ministry, and I think

that either the Minister for Finance adjusts it or increases it when he is bringing the Mid- Year Budget Review because majority of the service providers have not been paid.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister and Hon Members, he has provided the answer that when you are coming for the Mid-Year Budget Review, you consider it. So, I will therefore put the Question; it is a proposal rather than an amendment

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister is amenable to such suggestions, and for the period of time that we have engaged him, he is such a good Friend. We want him on record, and he must say something.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister for Finance, we —

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, may I finish?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: All right, I was just calling upon him to—They say “Ato is Forsing” so, they want your voice to be placed on record.

Dr C. A. B. Forson: Mr Speaker, I have noted the concern raised by the Hon Deputy Minority Chief Whip, and I would consider that when preparing the for the Mid-Year Budget Review.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, yesterday, the Hon Minister for Local

Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs laid Papers on behalf of the Hon Minister for Finance. The service providers are under him; he is suffering. He is in charge of five Ministries. He is in charge of Local Government, Chieftaincy, Sanitation, and Special Initiatives; these are all under his Ministry. So, they should be able to increase his money, instead of buying a lot of aircraft; one for the President and the other for himself.

Second Schedule to Long Title ordered to stand part of the Bill.

1:10 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, that brings us to the end of the Consideration Stage. Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we will take the item numbered 22.

BILL — THIRD READING

The Appropriation (No. 2) Bill, 2025

Minister for Finance (Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That the Appropriation (No. 2) Bill, 2025 be now read the Third time.

Mr Speaker, in doing so, let me use this opportunity to thank Hon Members for their dedication and contribution

throughout the Budget season. It has been six weeks of intensive debate and comment. I want to say that we do not take that lightly at all. All the comments have been taken into consideration. Going into the mid-year, we will do our best to factor some of the suggestions into the Mid-Year Budget Review and make the necessary amendments. I thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Habib?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, before the Motion is seconded, the Minister is introducing something alien to our Rules. We do not move a Motion and in between moving it, we comment and talk. The Motion should have been seconded and passed before the Minister for Finance came. What he has done is wrong. So, the Motion should be seconded before the Minister for Finance comes to thank us.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib, with all due respect, moving a Motion goes with some statement or explanation. It is only after seconding the Motion that I open the floor for other Members of the House to debate. So, Hon Habib, I beg to differ. The Rules are very clear, that when we are moving a Motion —

Any seconder?

Vice Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Richard Acheampong): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion and thank the House for supporting us.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

The Appropriation (No.2) Bill, 2025
— *read the Third time and passed.*

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Ayariga: The item numbered 12, Mr Speaker.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: The Leader has given indication, all in the spirit of ensuring that we dispense of business as soon as possible (ASAP) and that we can rise on time. With the Appropriation (No. 2) Bill, 2025, we had wanted to come to a second Consideration Stage, but we engaged the Minister. I want to commend him. He has shown magnanimity in terms of some considerations and matters that have to be dealt with. I want to place on record that the Minister has shown good leadership, especially in this regard, specific to Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC) and other matters. I want to urge him to continue in that spirit.

Now, the Majority Chief Whip's back is not looking too happy; it is a fact. We are rising in a few hours. Are they happy? The Minister is here. There are matters that the Majority Chief Whip must follow up on. Are they sure we are properly constituted and we can rise? He must be speaking to this concern. His Backbench is not happy. Look at their faces. The Minister is here. Let us do the needful. The Leader should make the House happy, so that in a few minutes,

we can all rise as a whole. There are very important matters. The Minister is here, so let us deal with them.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I want to assure him that he has nothing to worry about. He wants to know whether they are happy. Are you happy? [*Hear! Hear!*] I can assure everybody that all outstanding commitments have been dealt with. I am sure Hon Habib knows, so there is no problem.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Motion numbered 12. Chairperson of the Committee?

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I keep advising my Colleagues that Order 217(3) allows any Member of the Committee to present the Committee's Report. I am the Vice-Chairperson of the Committee.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Richard Acheampong, as a matter of fact, I called on the Chairperson of the Committee. In the absence of the Chairperson, if the Vice-Chairperson or a Member is going to present the report, we need to know as a House, and the record will show that the report is being presented by the Vice-Chairperson or a Member of the House. It is not automatic that a Member can get up in the name of the Chairperson of the Committee and begin moving a Motion slated for the Chairperson of the Committee.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, you are absolutely right. The Chairperson is unavoidably absent. He is attending to other very important matters. So, in lieu of him, the Vice-Chairperson is capable of presenting a report and moving the Motion on his behalf.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Chief Whip that is the application before us.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we will not litigate this matter. I see the Minister for Finance in the House, and he has also indicated that all the outstanding matters will be dealt with. In that spirit, he can go ahead and lay the Paper.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity. Let me thank my Colleagues. Today is the last day, so they are cooperating very well.

MOTION

Indicative Debt Treatment Menus between GoG and Individual Commercial Lenders for Restructuring of Commercial Debt

Vice Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Richard Acheampong) on behalf of the Chairperson of the Committee: Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That this honourable House adopts the Report of the Finance Committee on the Indicative Debt Treatment

Menus between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Finance) and individual commercial lenders for the restructuring of the outstanding Commercial Debt of two billion, seven hundred million United States Dollars (US\$2,700,000,000.00).

I call on the Hansard department to capture the entire Report as having been read whilst I read out the conclusion.

Introduction

On Wednesday, 3rd December, 2025, the Hon Deputy Minister for Finance, Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem, presented to Parliament the Indicative Debt Treatment Menus between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Finance) and Individual Commercial Lenders for the Restructuring of the Outstanding Commercial Debt of two billion, seven hundred million United States Dollars (US\$2,700,000,000.00) for approval in accordance with Article 181 of the 1992 Constitution.

Subsequent to the presentation, the Indicative Debt Treatment Menus was referred to the Finance Committee for consideration and report in accordance with Standing Order 226 of Parliament.

Deliberations

The Committee, in considering the Referral, met with the Hon Deputy Minister for Finance, Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem and the technical team of the Ministry of Finance and officials

from the Legislative Drafting Division of the Attorney-General's Department. The Committee is grateful to them for honouring the invitation and assisting in its deliberations.

Documents Referred

- i. Constitution of the Republic of Ghana, 1992;
- ii. Standing Orders of Parliament; and
- iii. Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921).

Background

Government has proposed an Indicative Debt Treatment Menu to restructure about US\$2.7 billion in outstanding commercial debt and is seeking the approval of the House in accordance with Section 56(1) of the Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921).

On 19th December 2022, the Government suspended debt service payments on most external debt — including Eurobonds, commercial loans, and most bilateral debts — pending an orderly restructuring. The debt moratorium was an interim emergency measure as Ghana negotiated a US\$3 billion Extended Credit Facility (ECF) programme with the International Monetary Fund (IMF) to restore macroeconomic stability and debt sustainability. Under the IMF programme, Ghana committed to reduce its debt-to-GDP ratio below 55 per cent

by 2028 and its external debt service-to-revenue ratio under 18 per cent from 2028. To achieve the goals, the Government launched a three-pronged debt restructuring; Domestic Debt Exchange Programme (DDEP), Official Bilateral Debt and Eurobond Debt Exchange.

Having tackled domestic, official, and bondholder debt, Ghana now focuses on the remaining 7 per cent of debt: about \$2.7 billion owed to over 50 commercial lenders. Unlike the other categories, these commercial loans (primarily trade credits, bank loans and supplier financings) have no collective framework, meaning Ghana must negotiate one-on-one deals with each creditor. The creditors include international banks from Europe, Asia, and Africa, contractors and other institutions that provided loans for various projects. A coordinated approach is needed to ensure these creditors provide relief on terms comparable to the official and bondholder agreements.

The initiative is therefore the final phase of Ghana's comprehensive debt restructuring programme under its IMF-supported recovery plan. It follows earlier domestic, bilateral and Eurobond debt operations and is designed to relieve Ghana's debt burden and restore sustainability. The debt treatment menu offers commercial creditors a set of restructuring options, ranging from rescheduling with low interest to nominal haircuts, that aim to achieve fair burden-sharing in line with deals already struck with official creditors and bondholders.

Completing this commercial debt restructuring is critical for Ghana to regain macroeconomic stability, meet IMF programme targets and put its public debt on a sustainable path.

Observations

A brief about the Commercial Debt Restructuring Process

The Committee observed that Ghana must negotiate separately with each of the dozens of commercial creditors and has therefore developed an Indicative Debt Treatment Menu to serve as a common framework. The menu outlines a limited set of restructuring options that Ghana is prepared to offer, ensuring consistency across negotiations.

The Committee was informed that the Ministry will invite each creditor to consider a standardised menu of debt treatment options. The options include various combinations of principal haircut, interest rate reduction or cap and extension of grace and maturity periods. Presenting the same menu to all creditors sets the stage for a uniform approach, making it easier to satisfy the comparability requirement.

The use of a common menu and adherence to comparability principles helps streamline the process and facilitate negotiations. It also positions Ghana as negotiating in good faith and evenly with all lenders, reducing the risk of holdouts or legal challenges. The end result sought is a comprehensive set of bilateral deals that collectively deliver the needed debt relief to restore

sustainability and no deal will be finalised unless it is comparable in effect to those of other creditors. The stance motivates creditors to agree to a menu option fairly quickly.

The Committee was also informed that the Official Creditor Committee (OCC) is indirectly involved by setting the benchmark for relief and will evaluate each tentative agreement to ensure it meets the standard before giving its nod. The external oversight discourages any creditor from pushing for an overly easy deal. Ghana's commitment not to favour any creditor also preserves inter-creditor equity and reduces legal risks.

The Committee was further informed that Ghana will seek formal approval of the agreed terms from the OCC and endorsement from the IMF. The IMF's concern is that the deal achieves the needed debt relief for programme objectives and the OCC's concern is that the creditor is contributing its fair share. The involvement of the OCC and IMF at the approval stage also provides credibility that the outcomes will achieve the intended debt relief.

The Committee observed that the Indicative Debt Treatment Menu offers three (3) main restructuring options to the commercial lenders. Each option represents a different balance of upfront debt reduction relative to the length of repayment and interest rate, but all are calibrated to provide Ghana a significant relief. When a creditor and government converge on one of the options that satisfies both parties, they

reach an Agreement in Principle (AIP). The AIP typically covers the core financial terms: the adjusted principal amount (if a haircut is applied), the new interest rate (or coupon structure), the grace period, if payments are deferred for some years and the new repayment schedule (amortisation profile and final maturity date).

Government and the creditor will draw up the restructuring agreement or amended loan contract to legally implement the AIP terms. This could involve new bond instruments being issued to the creditor or amendments to the original loan agreements. Once documentation is agreed, the deal is signed by both parties, making it binding.

Debt Treatment Options for Commercial Lenders

The following provides an explanation of the three (3) options:

(a) Option 1. OCC-like Treatment

- i. Amounts Recognised: Principal amount outstanding.
- ii. Treatment: Suspension and rescheduling of all debt service falling due between 20th December 2022 and (1st January 2026 or 1st January 2029).
- iii. The repayments following the debt service suspension period will be made according to initial contractual terms.
- iv. Reimbursement of suspended debt service between 1st January

2035 and (1st January 2036 or 1st January 2045) with a capitalisation rate of 0 per cent - 3 per cent to be applied to the rescheduled amounts.

(b) Option 2. Nominal Haircut, higher interest rate and shorter maturities.

- i. Amounts Recognised: Principal and interest accrue and recognised until settlement date.
- ii. Nominal haircut: 25 per cent -50 per cent.
- iii. Average Interest rate: 1 per cent - 5 per cent.
- iv. Redemption schedule: Principal reimbursement between 2025 and [2029 - 2038].

(c) Option 3. No nominal haircut, lower interest rates and longer maturities.

- i. Amounts Recognised: Principal and interest accrue and recognised until settlement date.
- ii. Nominal haircut: 0 per cent.
- iii. Average Interest rate: 1 per cent - 2.5 per cent.
- iv. Redemption schedule: Principal reimbursement between 2025 and [2033 - 2042].

Each of these options yields a substantial debt relief contribution when evaluated against Ghana's debt sustainability metrics. According to the menu analysis, the present value reduction ranges from about 20 per cent for the milder relief up to 55 per cent for the most relief depending on the option chosen.

In summary, the menu gives flexibility for different creditors to accept different forms of relief, but any chosen path achieves significant burden-sharing. The Government can mix-and-match these options across creditors yet still reach the overall debt reduction needed. The menu approach also simplifies negotiations and provides a transparent and fair basis for all parties.

The following table lists the major individual commercial lenders to Ghana and their exposures. It shows each lender's outstanding loan principal as of end-2022, the past-due interest (PDI) accumulated up to end-2024 and the resulting total claim as of end-2024 (combining principal + unpaid interest). All figures are in the currency

of the original loan agreement (USD or EUR) and are based on creditor submissions. It also illustrates the composition of the \$2.7 billion commercial debt that is to be restructured:

Creditor (Agent)	Outstanding Principal (End-2022)	Past-Due Interest (End-2024)	Total Claim (End-2024)
Deutsche Bank (DB)	€262.4 m	€47.2 m	€309.6 m
ING Bank	€127.1 m	€18.9 m	€146.0 m
“Saderea” Ad Hoc Committee	\$117.4 m	\$28.3 m	\$145.7 m
Standard Chartered Bank	\$85.5 m	\$17.7 m	\$103.2 m
Investec	€15.2 m	€4.3 m	€19.5 m
Tahal (Israel)	\$39.1 m	\$4.0 m	\$43.1 m
HSBC	\$28.9 m	\$6.2 m	\$35.0 m
BNP Paribas	\$28.3 m	\$7.8 m	\$36.1 m
Commerzbank	€19.3 m	€2.6 m	€21.8 m
J.P. Morgan (JPM)	\$15.6 m	\$4.6 m	\$20.2 m
Israel Discount Bank	\$13.2 m	\$2.6 m	\$15.8 m
Intesa Sanpaolo S.p.A.	€13.0 m	€2.1 m	€15.1 m
KfW (Germany)	\$7.2 m	\$2.5 m	\$9.7 m
Bank Hapoalim	\$5.3 m	\$0.9 m	\$6.2 m
ČSOB (Czech)	€2.9 m	€0.4 m	€3.2 m
Raiffeisen Bank International	€4.4 m	€0.4 m	€4.9 m
Rabobank	€4.3 m	€0.4 m	€4.7 m
Sinohydro (China)	\$295.6 m	\$26.3 m	\$321.9 m
Industrial & Comml. Bank of China	\$199.2 m	\$22.1 m	\$221.3 m
China Development Bank (CDB)	\$180.2 m	\$0.0 m	\$180.2 m
China Int’l Water & Electric (CIWE)	\$112.5 m	\$12.6 m	\$126.1 m
Poly Changda (China)	\$50.0 m	\$14.2 m	\$64.2 m
African Export–Import Bank (Afrexim)	\$760.5 m	\$127.9 m	\$888.4 m
African Trade Insurance (ATI)	\$220.1 m	\$41.4 m	\$261.5 m

Source: Government of Ghana, Indicative Debt Treatment Menu – Appendix 1

Conclusion

The Committee is of the view that the Indicative Debt Treatment Menu presents a pragmatic and equitable approach to resolve Ghana's debt in a manner acceptable to all stakeholders. The Government's request to Parliament is an approval for the finalisation of the deals, having provided a clear outline of the terms. With Parliament's consent and cooperative negotiations by government, Ghana can secure the debt relief needed from its commercial lenders, setting the stage for a return to solvency, improved creditworthiness and a stronger foundation for economic growth.

The Committee accordingly recommends to the House to adopt the Report and approve the Indicative Debt Treatment Menus between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Finance) and individual commercial lenders for the restructuring of the outstanding Commercial Debt of US\$2,700,000,000.00.

Mr Speaker, the conclusion is at page 8 of the Committee's Report.

1:20 p.m.

Deputy Minister for Finance (Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem) (MP): Mr Speaker, I beg to support the Motion, and to call this House to approve the indicative debt treatment menus between the Republic of Ghana and over 50 of our commercial lenders.

Mr Speaker, you recall that everybody in this House remembers the

process that was started in 2023 to restructure our debt. And it started with the famous domestic debt exchange programme that sought to replace some notes and bonds to the tune of US\$20.3 billion with new ones, with this associated painful haircut that happened in this country.

After that, there have been other processes, including the restructuring of Eurobonds, also in 2024. In June this year, this House gave approval for the indicative terms for the restructuring of our bilateral loans. Subsequent to that, the Ministry of Finance has engaged with some of our bilateral lenders and has successfully signed the Agreement with a number of countries, about seven of them so far, including China, Spain, the United Kingdom, and, recently, the Czech Republic.

What is outstanding is US\$2.7 billion of our commercial loans, and when we do this, it will bring finality to the process of the debt restructuring. So, we have presented about three scenarios that have been duly captured in the Report. The first scenario is the one that this House has already approved for the bilateral loans. The other two are indicated in the Report. So, we want to call on this House to approve this so it will allow the Ministry of Finance to conclude negotiations with the commercial lenders.

I so submit, Mr Speaker.

Question proposed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Motion moved and seconded. It is for the consideration of the House.

Yes, Hon First Deputy Minority Whip?

First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, having listened to the Deputy Minister for Finance, I am convinced that we need this. He needed to admit that the current economic stability that we are having in the system is due to this very arrangement.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance, Dr Forson, is stabilising part of the economy because of the debt restructuring that our creditors are not supposed to service our debt for some time. Definitely, when one looks clearly, this Government and the Minister for Finance have not initiated anything to stabilise the economy either through micro or macroeconomic indicators. All that we are enjoying is due to the fact that US\$2.7 billion have been restructured, and that our creditors are not coming after us; our creditors are not asking us to service the loans; and our creditors are not telling us to pay for the loans. It is because of these freebies and the holidays that the Minister for Finance is enjoying, that is the reason the dollar is stable. The dollar is very stable because he is not paying our debtors. He is not servicing the loans that we have accrued. That is the reason.

Mr Speaker, there is nothing like NPP debt. We have debt of the Republic of Ghana. Every loan or debt that was

inherited was contracted in the name of the Republic.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib, with all due respect, nobody has placed on record the NPP debt. So, why are you talking about NPP debt?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am guided. I want to add that every debt that is contracted is between the Republic of Ghana and for that matter, the Minister for Finance. We are seeing that the dollar is stabilising, even though we have been told that the Bank of Ghana has injected some US\$10 billion into the system.

I am very surprised that today's exchange rate is still at GHC11.50. Because if they inject that kind of capital of US\$10 billion into the economy, they are not servicing our debts, they are not paying any interest, there is a suspension of all interests on our loans, and yet, the dollar is still doing GHC11.00. That is very surprising. Mr Speaker, the dollar against the cedi should have been performing around GHC7.00 or GHC8.00, looking at what is in the system now. Mr Speaker, US\$10 billion into this economy; we are not supposed to service our debts for so many years, and our external creditors are not chasing us to make payment.

Mr Speaker, the Committee concluded by saying:

“After careful consideration, the Committee noted that the debt distraction was critical in supporting the Government to

restore sustainable micro-stability and debt sustainability.”

Mr Speaker, with this paragraph, it is very clear as to what we are getting in the economy. Dr Ato Forson and the NDC Government have done nothing to make us enjoy the single-digit inflation that we are having. They have done nothing to make us enjoy a very stable currency. This is because it is stated in this Report, the first paragraph, as I have read.

Mr Speaker, I will hammer on it again, that:

“After careful consideration, the committee noted that the debt restructuring was critical in supporting the Government to restore sustainable micro-stability and debt sustainability.”

Mr Speaker, without much, I support this approval. This will go a long way to help the Minister for Finance, businesses will go on very well in the economy, and people will know that what is happening currently in Ghana’s economy is because of the good work that was done by President Akufo-Addo’s Government. The negotiation on the debt restructuring and the debt holidays that were given to us is what we are enjoying currently.

Minister for Finance (Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson) (MP): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I want to say that what we are seeking to do today is to get approval from this House for us to get the contractors who lent money to Ghana, and for some reason, Ghana defaulted in the servicing of our debt in 2022, and as

a result, most of these contracts have come to a stall.

Mr Speaker, a typical one has to do with the Sino-Hydro Project. If you go to Takoradi today, the PTC interchange is stalled. Mr Speaker, until we approve this, we will not be able to complete that project. What we are seeking to do is to make sure that this is approved for us to be able to agree with the contractors for them to come to site.

Mr Speaker, unfortunately, our dear country defaulted on the servicing of our debt in 2022. Ghana did not service its debt in 2023 and 2024. In fact, in 2023, when we did not service those debts that we defaulted, the cedi depreciated.

1:30 p.m.

In 2024 when we did not service the debt, the cedi depreciated. So today, if the cedi is appreciating, it is not because we are failing to service our debt.

Mr Speaker, in fact, this year, we are servicing our debt with GH¢59 billion. So, it is wrong for anyone to assume that Ghana is not servicing a debt. We are paying GH¢8.9 billion to service external debt alone, and GH¢51 billion in servicing domestic debt. So, Mr Speaker, it cannot be the case that Ghana is not servicing its debt.

Mr Speaker, let me put it on record that the stability we are seeing is not because of debt restructuring. Debt restructuring started in 2022. Why is it that the country could not see stability in 2023? Why did we not see stability in

2024? Why are we suddenly seeing stability? If they want to share in the glory of President Mahama, they should ask permission from him, and he will gladly allow them to take some 1 per cent of the glory that he is enjoying.

Mr Speaker, let me say that we have come far, but there is still more work to be done. In the coming years, we will take steps to correct some of the mistakes that were made in the past and bring this country to economic stability.

Mr Speaker, I so submit.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, consequential Resolution numbered 13.

Minister for Finance?

RESOLUTION

Indicative Debt Treatment Menus between GoG and Individual Commercial Lenders for Restructuring of Commercial Debts

Minister for Finance (Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

WHEREAS by the provisions of article 181(5) of the Constitution the terms and conditions of any international business or economic transaction to which the Government of Ghana is a party shall not come into operation unless the said terms and conditions have been laid before

Parliament and approved by Parliament by a Resolution supported by the votes of a majority of all Members of Parliament.

PURSUANT to the provisions of the said article 181(5) of the Constitution, and at the request of the Government of Ghana acting through the Minister responsible for Finance, there has been laid before Parliament the terms and conditions of an Indicative Debt Treatment Menus between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Finance) and individual commercial lenders for the restructuring of the outstanding Commercial Debt of Two Billion, Seven Hundred Million United States Dollars (US\$2,700,000,000.00).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, any seconder?

Vice Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Richard Acheampong): Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, let us turn to the *Order Paper Addendum* for us to lay the Master Gas Agreement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, at the Commencement of public Business, Presentation of Papers, the item numbered 1. Minister for Finance.

PAPER

By the Minister for Finance (Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson)—

Master Gas Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Finance and the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC), GNPC Exploration and Production Limited, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments, and PetroSA Ghana Limited (as Contractor Parties).

Referred to the Committee on Energy and Leadership of Finance Committee.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, petroleum agreements are mainly for Committee on Energy. I do not know why Finance Committee will come in. If the leadership of the Finance Committee is asked to assist, that would be fine.

Dr C. A. B. Forson: Mr Speaker, just to clarify, the reason why the Finance Committee will be needed is that there is a form of CIT backstop for which the involvement of the Finance Committee will be important. The reason I am involved is that the Minister for Energy and Green Transition required that the Agreement is jointly signed by the Ministry of Finance and Ministry of Energy and Green Transition, and so we require the two Committees to sit and appreciate what is in the document.

So, I suggest that the Finance Committee, or at the minimum,

leadership of the Finance Committee be involved in considering this Agreement.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the item numbered 2 on the *Order Paper Addendum*.

Yes, so the referral is to Committee on Energy and Finance Committee.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the contention is that leadership of the Finance Committee should rather join the Committee on Energy to consider it. We will not litigate.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. I would withdraw the earlier referral and to say that the Paper presented is referred to the Committee on Energy with leadership of the Finance Committee assisting.

Yes, the item numbered 2 on the *Order Paper Addendum*.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources has just stepped out of the Chamber, so we pray that the Minister for Finance does this on his behalf.

I humbly submit.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, but for nothing I would have opposed. Because the Minister for Finance is seeking to do the needful, we will allow him. The Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, a while ago was in the Chamber and he suddenly vanished.

Anyway, we are not opposed. He can go ahead.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Minister for Finance, you may do so on behalf of the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources.

INSTRUMENT

Minerals and Mining (Royalties) Regulations, 2025

Laid by the Minister for Finance (Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson) on behalf of Minister for Lands and Natural Resources.

Referred to the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation.

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah (NPP — Okaikwei Central): Mr Speaker, duly acknowledged, but I just sent a message to the Minister for Finance that in Zimbabwe, because of the increase in the royalties in mineral resources in their 2026 Budget and the disturbances with the introduction of these royalties, they have withdrawn the introduction of such royalties and the increases. So, it is a word of caution to him and I have sent it to him. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may we pray you that we take the Motion numbered 26. I know Hon Annoh-Dompreh is in full support.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Motion numbered 26, Minister for Education.

MOTION

Suspension of Standing Order 104(1)

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 104(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that a Motion shall not be debated until at least two sitting days have elapsed after the notice to move the Motion is given, the Motion for the Second Reading of the Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies (Amendment) Bill, 2025 may be moved today.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, procedural Motion numbered 26 is moved. Any seconder?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Substantive Motion numbered 27.

BILL — SECOND READING

Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies (Amendment) Bill, 2025

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu) (MP): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That the Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies (Amendment) Bill, 2025 be now read a Second time.

1:40 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the University was named in 2020, and there were some petitions to President John Dramani Mahama. This is best practice worldwide; some universities are even named after the communities where they are established. That is why we have Cambridge University, Oxford University, and Yale, but Mr Speaker, let me state emphatically that the President and Government recognises that individuals have made significant contributions to the development of our country: political, social, economic contributions, and may deserve of some recognition in other ways but not naming the public institutions of higher learning after them.

Mr Speaker, this Bill, which was established by Act 1001, seeks to rename the Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies to the University of Business and Integrated Development Studies.

I so submit thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I will call on the Chairman of the Committee to present the Committee's Report.

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Peter Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, I beg to support the Motion, and in so doing, present the Committee's Report. I urge *Hansard* to capture the entire Report as having been read.

Introduction

The Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies (Amendment) Bill, 2025 was laid before Parliament on Thursday, 18th December, 2025 by the Hon Minister for Education, Mr Haruna Iddrisu, in accordance with Article 106(1) of the 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana and Order 159(3) of the Standing Orders of Parliament.

Pursuant to Article 106(4) of the 1992 Constitution and Order 250 of the Standing Orders of Parliament, the Speaker subsequently referred the Bill to the Committee on Education for consideration and report.

Deliberations

The Committee met with the Hon Minister for Education on Thursday, 18th December, 2025 to consider the Bill.

The Committee expresses its profound gratitude to the Hon Minister for Education for attending upon the

Committee and providing clarification on the issues raised at the meeting.

Reference Documents

The Committee referred to the following documents during the deliberations:

- i. The Constitution of the Republic of Ghana, 1992;
- ii. The Standing Orders of Parliament, 2024;
- iii. The Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies Act, 2020 (Act 1001);
- iv. The Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies (Amendment) Bill, 2025;
- v. The Education Regulatory Bodies Act, 2020 (Act 1023);
- vi. The Education Strategic Plan (ESP 2018-2030), 2018; and
- vii. The Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921).

Background

The Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies was established by an Act of Parliament (Act 1001) passed on 2nd August, 2019, with assent given on 23rd August, 2019.

The Bill seeks to amend the Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies Act, 2020 (Act 1001) to change the name of the University to the University of Business and Integrated Development Studies.

Purpose of the Bill

The Bill seeks to amend the Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies Act, 2020 (Act 1001) to change the name of the University to the University of Business and Integrated Development Studies.

The change of the name of the University fosters stronger relationships between the University and relevant stakeholders to boost public interest, leading to higher enrolment funding, and support from alumni and stakeholders. This renewed interest will further drive broader investment in higher education, benefiting both the educational and economic landscapes.

Many universities globally are changing names to reflect contemporary values and social justice. By following this trend, the University will enhance its global competitiveness and appeal to international students.

Summary of Provisions of the Bill

Clause 1 of the Bill amends the relevant provisions of Act 1001 to change the name of the University to the University of Business and Integrated Development Studies.

Clause 2 provides for the consequential amendment of relevant enactments. Under the clause, a reference in any other enactment to "Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies" is to be construed as a reference to "University of Business and Integrated Development Studies".

Observations

The observations below reflect the Committee's review of the Bill, taking into account its deliberations and the inputs received from stakeholders.

Scope of the Proposed Amendments

The Committee finds that the primary objective of the Bill is to revise the official name of the institution, replacing personal or historically derived designations with more functional and descriptive titles. The Committee further observes that the proposed amendment does not introduce any substantive adjustments to the university's governance framework, statutory mandate, academic direction, or operational structures.

Justification for the Proposed Renaming

The renaming of the institution is advanced as part of a broader policy initiative aimed at aligning with international standards while fostering national unity. The rationale presented highlights that the existing names have been viewed by certain stakeholders, particularly traditional authorities and community leaders as exclusionary or potentially divisive. These concerns

were formally conveyed to the Ministry through petitions and consultations.

In evaluating the justification, the Committee considered both the arguments put forward by the Minister and the wider context of global naming practices. While some reservations were expressed regarding whether the proposed name fully reflects international norms, given that many renowned universities, such as Oxford, Cambridge, and the University of Ghana, retain clear geographic identifiers.

The Committee acknowledged that the adoption of generic, non-personal institutional titles is also consistent with established international practice.

The Committee therefore concludes that the proposed renaming is underpinned by a commitment to inclusivity and national cohesion, while remaining aligned with naming conventions commonly observed across higher education systems worldwide.

Safeguarding Financial Efficiency in the Coming Year

The Committee acknowledges that institutional resources including letterheads, branded stationery, and other official materials are customarily produced in accordance with corporate governance standards and must reflect the institution's official name. As the 2025 financial year concludes, preparations for allocating funds toward the procurement of such items for the subsequent year are expected to commence.

Within this context, the Committee observes that authorising expenditure on materials bearing the current name of the institution, only for that name to be altered in the first quarter of 2026, would inevitably lead to additional costs arising from rebranding. Such duplication of expenditure is deemed inconsistent with principles of prudent financial management.

Consequently, the Committee underscores the importance of addressing the Bill expeditiously. Prompt consideration will enable the university to begin the new financial year with certainty regarding its official designation and to proceed with the acquisition of branded materials in a manner that reflects fiscal responsibility and sound planning.

Significance of Geographic Identifiers in University Naming

The Committee underscores the importance of integrating geographic or location-based identifier – “Wa” into the proposed name of the university. This measure is regarded as vital for reinforcing institutional identity and ensuring that the university can be clearly distinguished within the broader national higher education system.

Furthermore, the Committee notes that the inclusion of geographic identifier is consistent with existing legislative provisions, many of which already specify the locations of principal campuses.

Aligning the new institutional name with these established conventions will enhance coherence across the sector and

strengthen recognition of the university within both academic and public domains.

Fostering National Identity and Promoting Inclusivity

Stakeholders have persistently advocated for the renaming of the institution from Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies the University to the University of Business and Integrated Development Studies, Wa.

The Committee noted that, the Ministry of Education conducted consultations with relevant groups to guide both the proposed renaming and the drafting of the Bill.

The Committee observes that the revised name is expected to strengthen the institution's ties with its host community and strategic partners. This enhanced relationship is anticipated to generate wider public interest, which could lead to increased student enrolment, improved funding opportunities, and greater alumni and stakeholder support. Collectively, these outcomes are projected to encourage broader investment in the higher education sector, with positive implications for both academic advancement and national economic growth.

In view of these considerations, the Committee affirms that stakeholder perspectives and contributions were duly incorporated, thereby ensuring that the renaming process embodies the principles of inclusivity and reinforces national identity.

Proposed Amendments

The Committee proposed the attached amendments during its deliberations.

Conclusion

The Committee upon a thorough examination of the Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies (Amendment) Bill, 2025, affirms that the Bill is limited in scope to the renaming of the University. It introduces no changes to the institution's statutory mandate, governance framework, academic orientation, or operational structures.

The Committee further recognises the policy rationale advanced by the Minister for Education, particularly the emphasis on national cohesion, inclusive stakeholder participation, and alignment with international relevance.

In view of these considerations, the Committee recommends that the House adopt this Report and approve the passage of the Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies (Amendment) Bill, 2025.

Respectfully submitted.

Question proposed.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, let us do two on each Side, then we come to Leadership.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will give the floor to Dr Kabiru.

Dr Tiah Abdul Kabiru Mahama (NPP — Walewale): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I am a proud alumnus of the university.

Mr Speaker, the history of this university is that it was first a campus of the University for Development Studies, and it was known as the University for Development Studies, Wa Campus. We attended this University with pride because the course structure afforded us the opportunity for hands-on training and on-field practice. The campus was later established as a full-fledged University by the previous administration and renamed S. D. Dombo University for Business and Integrated Studies.

Mr Speaker, there are very good reasons why universities are named after prominent personalities, especially within the catchment areas where those universities are established. It is not only in Ghana that we have such universities named after prominent personalities. In other jurisdictions, universities are even named after towns. They are named after communities and some people who have contributed to humanity. It was for this reason that a very good decision was taken to rename the University for Development Studies, Wa Campus into S. D. Dombo University for Business and Integrated Development Studies.

Mr Speaker, I have read the memorandum accompanying this Bill; the first and foremost rationale for this decision is that it is evolving with the contemporary times. I do not see, and I have not read anywhere across the globe, where university names are reverted to

their previous names because the names they were given are not in good standing with any Government. What is even more worrying is that it was a campaign promise stated on the campaign platforms that, should the National Democratic Congress (NDC) win power, it would revert all universities named after people.

Mr Speaker, we are setting a very bad precedent where a President would be elected tomorrow and he would change the Kotoka International Airport to Accra International Airport or Ghana International Airport; change the Rawlings Park to Ghana Park; change every single landmark that has been used to honour great men and women of our country back because they are not in the good standing of the current Government. There is a popular saying that if a country does not honour its heroes, it is not worth dying for.

Mr Speaker, S. D. Dombo was a proud son of the Upper West Region. He contributed significantly to the shaping of Ghana's democracy. At a time when people thought that we could not have functional democracy, S. D. Dombo and his contemporaries were those who laid the cornerstone for the foundation of modern democracy. This House, which is a house of democracy, is going to dishonour the memory of such a man by the naming of one single institution after him. Mr Speaker, I am afraid that in the future, when Bernard Ahiafor, Member of Parliament, is to be honoured—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, please do not draw me into the debate.

Dr T. A. K. Mahama: Mr Speaker, all right. Should this House consider doing this against Hon Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor, when the people of the Volta Region, after he has contributed so much to the development of Ghana, want to honour him by naming an institution after him?

Mr Speaker, with the greatest of respect, I am appealing to the Government not to desecrate the memory.

1:50 p.m.

As we speak, S. D. Dombo will be turning in his grave that a country that he fought for, a country for which he sacrificed his family and even sacrificed his job security to lay the foundation of our modern-day democracy, is being desecrated by the very Members of Parliament who he once served alongside as a Member of this House. In the history of the formation of the New Patriotic Party (NPP), the then Northern People's Party, S. D. Dombo was the leader of the Northern People's Party. The Northern People's Party was the foremost political grouping that brought the North into the formation of the modern-day Ghana. Following the decision to ban all political parties that formed along tribal, ethnic or regional lines, the Northern People's Party amalgamated into the United Party (UP) which later evolved into the New Patriotic Party. This is the same man who was honoured under the previous regime. It does not matter where he came from.

I am not from the Upper West Region and I am not related to S. D. Dombo.

However, I fear for our democracy, and I fear for people who are willing to sacrifice for our country. I would want to urge the Minister for Education and also urge the President to take note that this will set a bad precedent if this House proceeds to change the names of all universities that have been named after prominent personalities. If we do that, we can be certain that this is as good as the tenure of the National Democratic Congress.

With these few words, Mr Speaker, I thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Kyei Asamoah, I believe that the Leaders will yield to you.

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah (NPP — Offinso North): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to speak on the Report presented by the Committee on Education. In fact, Mr Speaker, today is one of the saddest days in this country. A very sad day for this country. When the Hon Minister was speaking, he made reference to some universities. Mr Speaker, for your information and the information of this House, Harvard University was named after John Harvard. Yale University was named after Elihu Yale, who was a merchant and a philanthropist. Stanford University was founded and was named after Leland Stanford. Duke University was named after Washington Duke and James Duke. Mr Speaker, George Washington University was named after George Washington. We can go on and on and on. The top ten universities in this world were named after individuals.

The Hon Member spoke about C. K. Tedam and S. D. Dombo but I would like us to also focus on Akenten Appiah-Menka. Akenten Appiah-Menka was a distinguished Ghanaian lawyer and a politician—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, we are taking the Bills one after the other. We are not taking the Bill jointly. The Bill under reference has nothing to do with what you are talking about, so limit yourself to the Bill under reference.

Dr F. K. Asamoah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. So just to affirm the point I am making, we are setting a bad precedent for future generation. We are allowing the politics of this country to go beyond the boundaries within which it ought to operate.

Mr Speaker, what does changing the name John Hopkins University, one of the best universities in the world, take away from what John Hopkins was able to contribute? I thought the Hon Minister would come to this Chamber to request additional funding to support the university, so that it can embark on meaningful research, expand its infrastructure, and benefit from the Free Senior High School policy instituted by Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo and the NPP Government. This would ensure that the increasing number of students graduating from our second cycle institutions can have the opportunity to pursue tertiary education. We all know that economic development is always hinged on the gross tertiary enrolment ratio. Mr Speaker, for me, it is petty to

just change the name, for what? What we expect of the Hon Minister of Education is to come to this House and ask for more money for the university, so that our universities can undertake in-depth research, collaborate with industry, develop new products, and create new services so that this country can develop.

Mr Speaker, I believe this is an opportunity for the Minister to withdraw this Bill. This change is not going to improve this university in anyway. Rather, we are trying to tell Ghanaians not sacrifice or serve their nation. Mr Speaker, all these universities I mentioned were named after philanthropists, businessmen, and merchants. Perhaps, the Hon Minister needs to undertake a further review of the universities mentioned. None of those universities were arbitrarily named. Yale was named after an individual, Stanford was named after an individual, John Hopkins was named after an individual. Harvard, indeed, was named after John Harvard. So why are we changing the names of our universities?

Mr Speaker, what is happening today will add nothing to our tertiary education. It is not going to add extra funding to our tertiary education. We need the tertiary institutions that have been able to transform other countries to help transform this country, not institutions whose names are changed simply because of political promises.

Does it mean that, by the grace of God, *Inshallah*, when the NPP returns, we will also reverse the names? Mr

Speaker, the families and towns from which people like S. D. Dombo come, will remember today as one of the saddest days in their life. Today sends a message to young Ghanaians that it is not worth sacrificing for their country, not worth committing themselves to ensure that the country in which they were born in is developed.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, we urge the Hon Minister to withdraw this Bill. This is a bad precedent we are setting for future generations.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leadership?

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I am very sad. I am very sad today both as a politician and a legislator. I am very sad that the NDC Government is using our own Brother, Mr Haruna Iddrisu, who, per what he has achieved to his name is being used to set such a precedent. It will be a sad day if an institution is named after him, and it can easily be scrapped. Mr Speaker, before he became a legislator, Hon Haruna Iddrisu, was popularly called 'Harun Econs', in Tamale. Mr Speaker, he became National Youth Organiser of the NDC and later served as Minister for Communications, Minister for Labour, and Minister for Trade and Industry. He now serves as Minister for Education. Are we saying that one day, if an institution is named after such a person, we should scrap it?

Mr Speaker, S. D. Dombo, is a very distinguished personality in our national history, a leader of the then Northern People's Party, NPP, a co-founder of the UP/NPP tradition, a former Member of Parliament and at one time a Leader of this House. A university was named after him, and one political group just thinks that because he has affiliations with another political group, his name should be removed, without any justifiable reason. Hon Minister for Education, I think this is very bad, and I think you still have an opportunity at the Second Reading to withdraw this, and not proceed any further.

Mr Speaker, I strongly advise the Hon Minister for Education, I advise him strongly, that the very principles for which we know him and the principles we respect him for, should guide him not to proceed any further with changing this name, solely because it is in the name of Clement Kubindiwor Tedam. Like they said, the best universities in the world like Harvard were named after some. But one cannot mention four top universities in the world without Harvard. The same thing applies to the other names that are associated.

2:00 p.m.

If we look at exactly what the Government intends doing, it means that if one is not affiliated with the National Democratic Congress (NDC), they must and should not name any university after you.

Mr Speaker, there are so many reasons for which sometimes we name

universities after people. It is for celebrating our heroes and heroines. It is for historical purposes that we name universities after people. Who was Simon Diedong Dombo? He was a teacher, Member of Parliament and a chief. We have named a university after such a person and one political group thinks that because he was not affiliated to them, so the name should be scrapped? They are using his brother in the person of President Mahama and Hon Haruna Iddrisu, who are both Northerners, to scrap a name of a university which is named after a Northerner.

Hon Minister for Education, I am very sad. What the Majority Side has achieved for themselves today is something we have to fight for one day, if they are not around. If the Minister for Education has used today to scrap this name, I bet him that in future, they will use other people to scrap his name. I know his principle and what he stands for. I will advise him strongly to withdraw this Bill at this moment and not to proceed for us to go into Consideration Stage, not to talk about the Third Reading.

Mr Speaker, this is a very bad precedent that we are setting for this country. One day, our heroes will be forgotten. There are reasons we name universities after people. I am very sad that Members of Parliament (MP) from the Upper West such as Dr Jasaw are here and not saying anything about it. There is also the MPs for Daffiama-Bussie-Issa (DBI), Wa Central and Wa East, who are all here and this Government is doing this. *[Interruption]* It is very sad that the

MPs for Sissala East, Sissala West, Lambussie, Nandom, Wa East, Wa West, Wa Central are all here and then they have allowed one of their sons and fathers' name be scrapped from history. There is a reason for which it was named after him. We do not want to forget. We do not want S. D. Dombo to be forgotten.

Mr Speaker, I am very sad today. As a Member of Parliament, I will sacrifice for this country and one day, whatever I have toiled for would be scrapped just by presenting a legislation. I am very sad and I can see that Mr Ahmed Ibrahim is also very sad. I can see the Minister for Education does not want to do this, but he is under pressure to do it. The Hon Haruna Iddrisu that I know is a very respectful person. He respects chiefs and teachers from the North; he will not come to make sure that history is scrapped. This is an attempt to scrap the name of S. D. Dombo from the history of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, the President, John Dramani Mahama is a Northerner from Bole. Our Minister for Education is a Northerner from Tamale. Our Deputy Minister for Education is a Northerner from the Upper East and yet they want to do this to one of their colleagues. I am very sad. The Minister for Education should make sure that going through this Bill, we will oppose it with everything that we have. At Consideration Stage, we would vote on every clause of the Bill. They need a number of 138 Members in everything and we would oppose it with everything—*[Interruption]*—we will not allow it to happen.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib Iddrisu, you can make your points, but you know the implication of banging the table.

We have three Bills —

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, let me thank our Colleagues and to assure them that these changes are done in good faith and reflects historical guidance to the name of universities across the country. There is no ill feeling. S. D. Dombo remains S. D. Dombo; his contribution is recognised. If I were to ask my Colleague, what about P. K. Adama? Have they done something in honour of Bukari Kpegla Adama? He was also a stalwart of the United Party (UP) and the New Patriotic Party (NPP), precisely because of this reason, that is a thinking that named the university not after those persons; we can do other honours in their name, but certainly not those universities.

Mr Speaker, we should not lose sight. Even President Jerry John Rawlings, who dedicated his donation to establish the University of Development Studies (UDS) which has changed the fortunes of the North in terms of access to higher education, declined the University being named after him.

Mr Speaker, with this, I thank my Colleagues. Bless you, Mr Speaker. As noted by the Committee, thorough consultation is important to guide this. I thank you.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies (Amendment) Bill, 2025 is accordingly read a Second time.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Order! Order!

Hon Members, we are doing Government Business. If you would not take part, that does not mean you should shout.

Yes, the Motion numbered 28? Minister for Education?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I pray that, because the Reports are threefold, I pray that we take the Reports sequentially.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us go by the structure in the *Order Paper*. Minister for Education, take the Motion numbered 28.

MOTION

Suspension of Order 169(1)

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 169(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that when a bill has been read a second time, the Bill shall pass through a consideration stage which shall not be taken until at least two sitting days have elapsed, the Consideration

Stage of the Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies (Amendment) Bill, 2025 may be *taken* today.

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Peter Kwasi Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Question put Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, my humble prayer is that the advertised amendments are to be conveyed to this House via the *Order Paper Addendum 2*. It is still being processed. So, I pray that we take the Motion numbered 33 in respect of the Report for C. K. Tedom so that we get that done.

2:10 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. If that is the reason, I would accede to your request. The Motion numbered 33, Minister for Education?

BILL — SECOND READING

C. K. Tedom University of Technology and Applied Sciences (Amendment) Bill, 2025

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu) (MP): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That the C. K. Tedom University of Technology and Applied Sciences (Amendment) Bill, 2025 be now read a *second* time.

Mr Speaker, and in so doing to state that it is to amend the C.K Tedom University of Technology and Applied Sciences Act, 2019 to change the university and to reverse it to University of Technology and Applied Sciences, which is based in Navrongo. An earlier comment had it that if you take Navrongo, for instance and we are to do historical context of contribution of individuals in that area, the President received a number of petitions of protests against it. For instance, anybody from Navrongo, and I stand to be challenged, will want to honour Lawrence Rosario Abavana, but the university was not named after Abavana. But anybody from Navrongo knows Abavana's contribution to the development of Ghana and northern development. So many of these things, if not done well, further polarises and disunites the area. So, it is without prejudice to the standing of any personality and the recognition of those personalities' contribution to the development of their community, northern Ghana, and Ghana as a whole.

Mr Speaker, it is only fair that the university is named as University for Technology and Applied Sciences, Navrongo. So that we will reverse the name and to assure them— I heard my Colleague, Hon Dr Asamoah, talk about the Minister coming to move and support funding of universities under President Mahama's reset agenda. This year, all these universities received GH¢10 million from the Ministry of Education to support their activities. This is the first time ever the Vice Chancellor of C.K Tedom and the Chairman of their

Council were in my office to hail Government for this support.

Mr Speaker, into this year, I would be recognising eight more universities to benefit from it. In their eight years, they did not send a pesewa to support any of these universities.

Mr Speaker, I so move that the C.K Tedom University of Technology and Applied Sciences (Amendment) Bill, 2025 be now read the second time and to assure the Hon Member for Tolon—he knows there is a university which he hosts as a Member of Parliament (MP). There are many names in that area, including persons and personalities from Tolon, including Talena Yakubu. What happens? So, we are saying that in doing this, let the consultations be thorough and it should reflect the historical antecedents of the area. If you name one in honour of one and fail to do another, you may not be helping the cohesion of that society.

Mr Speaker, with this, I so move.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Chairperson of the Committee on Education may present the report of the Committee on the Bill.

Chairperson of the Committee on Education (Mr Peter Kwasi Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, I *beg* to present the report of the Committee on Education on the C. K. Tedom University of Technology and Applied Sciences (Amendment) Bill, 2025. In doing so, I urge *Hansard* to capture the report as

having been read as I read out the conclusion.

Mr Speaker, I so present. Thank you.

Introduction

The C. K. Tedom University of Technology and Applied Sciences (Amendment) Bill, 2025 was laid before Parliament on Thursday, 18th December, 2025 by the Hon Minister for Education, Mr Haruna Iddrisu, in accordance with Article 106(1) of the Constitution of the Republic of Ghana, 1992 and Order 159(3) of the Standing Orders of Parliament.

Pursuant to Article 106(4) of the 1992 Constitution and Order 250 of the Standing Orders of Parliament, the Speaker subsequently referred the Bill to the Committee on Education for consideration and report.

Deliberations

The Committee met with the Hon Minister for Education on Thursday, 18th December, 2025 to consider the Bill.

The Committee expresses its profound gratitude to the Hon Minister for Education for attending upon the Committee and providing clarification to issues raised at the meeting.

Reference Documents

The Committee referred to the following documents during the deliberations:

- i. The Constitution of the Republic of Ghana, 1992;
- ii. The Standing Orders of Parliament, 2024;
- iii. C. K. Tedom University of Technology and Applied Sciences Act, 2019 (Act 1000);
- iv. C. K. Tedom University of Technology and Applied Sciences (Amendment) Bill, 2025;
- v. The Education Regulatory Bodies Act, 2020 (Act 1023);
- vi. The Education Strategic Plan (ESP 2018-2030), 2018; and
- vii. The Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921).

Background

The C. K. Tedom University of Technology and Applied Sciences was established by an Act of Parliament (Act 1000) passed on 2nd August, 2019, with assent given on 23rd August, 2019.

The Bill seeks to amend the C. K. Tedom University of Technology and Applied Sciences Act, 2019 (Act 1000) to change the name of the University to the University of Technology and Applied Sciences, Navrongo.

Purpose of The Bill

The Bill seeks to amend the C. K. Tedom University of Technology and Applied Sciences Act, 2019 (Act 1000)

to change the name of the University to the University of Technology and Applied Sciences, Navrongo.

The change of the name of the University also fosters stronger relationships between the University and relevant stakeholders to boost public interest, leading to higher enrolment funding, and support from alumni and stakeholders. This renewed interest will further drive broader investment in higher education, benefiting both the educational and economic landscapes.

Many universities globally are changing names to reflect contemporary values and social justice. By following this trend, the University will enhance its global competitiveness and appeal to international students.

Summary of Provisions of the Bill

Clause 1 of the Bill amends the relevant provisions of Act 1000 to change the name of the University to the University of Technology and Applied Sciences.

Clause 2 provides for the consequential amendment of relevant enactments. Under the clause, a reference in any other enactment to “C. K. Tedam University of Technology and Applied Sciences” is to be construed as a reference to " University of Technology and Applied Sciences".

Observations

The observations below reflect the Committee’s review of the Bill, taking

into account its deliberations and the inputs received from stakeholders.

Scope of the Proposed Amendments

The Committee noted that the Bill’s central purpose is to alter the name of the institution in question, mainly by replacing personal or historically associated names with titles that are functional or descriptive in nature. It was further observed that the amendment does not affect any meaningful modifications to the university’s governance arrangements, statutory responsibilities, academic orientation, or operational systems.

Basis for the Proposed Name Change

The proposed renaming of the institution is presented as part of a broader effort to align with international best practice while promoting national unity. According to the justification provided, the current institutional names have been perceived by some stakeholders, particularly traditional authorities and community leaders, as exclusionary or potentially divisive. These concerns were formally communicated through petitions submitted to the Ministry.

In assessing the rationale, the Committee considered both the motivations advanced by the Minister and the broader context of global naming conventions. While questions were raised regarding whether the proposed name fully reflects international standards, especially given that many globally recognised universities retain

clear geographical identifiers such as Oxford, Cambridge, and the University of Ghana, the Committee also noted that the adoption of generic, non-personal institutional titles is widely accepted within international practice.

The Committee recognises that the rationale for the name change is grounded in efforts to enhance inclusivity and national cohesion, while also reflecting naming approaches commonly used in higher education systems around the world.

Ensuring Prudent Financial Planning for the Upcoming Year

The Committee recognises that institutional materials such as letterheads, branded stationery, and other official items are produced in line with established corporate governance standards and therefore bear the institution's official name. As the 2025 financial year draws to a close, preparations for committing funds toward the procurement of these materials for the ensuing year would ordinarily begin.

In this context, the Committee finds that authorising expenditure on items embossed with the current institutional name, only for that name to be changed within the first quarter of 2026, would result in unnecessary additional costs associated with rebranding. Such a sequence of expenditure would not reflect sound financial management.

For this reason, the Committee considers it essential that the Bill be addressed without delay. Timely

consideration will allow the university to enter the new financial year with clarity regarding its official name and to proceed with the procurement of branded materials in a fiscally responsible manner.

Importance of Including Geographic Identifiers in University Names

The Committee emphasises the value of incorporating clear geographic or location-based identifier “Navrongo” into the proposed name of the university. This approach is viewed as essential for strengthening institutional identity and ensuring that the university is easily distinguishable within the national higher education landscape.

In addition, the Committee considers the use of the geographic identifier as consistent with existing legislative frameworks, many of which already reference the locations of main campuses.

Aligning the new name with these established conventions will promote coherence across the sector and support effective institutional recognition.

Advancing National Identity and Strengthening Inclusivity

The Committee noted that stakeholders have consistently advocated for the renaming of the institution from C. K. Tedam University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development to the University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development, Kumasi.

In response to these calls, the Ministry of Education undertook a series

of stakeholder engagements to inform both the proposed name change and the drafting of the accompanying Bill.

The Committee notes that the revised name is expected to reinforce the institution's connection with its surrounding community and key partners. This strengthened relationship is anticipated to generate greater public interest, which may translate into higher student enrolment, expanded funding prospects, and enhanced support from alumni and other stakeholders. Collectively, these developments are projected to stimulate broader investment in the higher education sector, with positive effects on both educational outcomes and the wider economy.

In light of these considerations, the Committee affirms that the perspectives and contributions of relevant stakeholders were duly incorporated, ensuring that the renaming process reflects principles of inclusivity and national identity.

Proposed Amendments

The Committee proposed the attached amendments during its deliberations.

Conclusion

After a thorough review of the C. K. Tedom University of Technology and Applied Sciences (Amendment) Bill, 2025, the Committee concludes that the proposed legislation is limited to the renaming of the University and does not introduce any changes to its statutory mandate, governance arrangements,

academic direction, or operational structure. The Committee recognises the policy justifications presented by the Minister for Education, particularly the aims of promoting national cohesion, strengthening stakeholder engagement, and aligning with international standards.

In light of these considerations, the Committee recommends that the House adopts this Report and proceed to pass the C. K. Tedom University of Technology and Applied Sciences (Amendment) Bill, 2025.

Respectfully submitted.

Question proposed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Motion moved. Report presented.

Yes, Hon Ntim Fordjour?

Rev John Ntim Fordjour (NPP — Assin South): Mr Speaker, thank you. I rise to contribute to the Motion under discussion and to indicate that today is a very sad day for Ghana. There is a popular saying that a nation that fails to honour its heroes is not worth dying for. All these heroes whose names have been attached to these universities were done for a reason.

Mr Speaker, at a time when advanced nations are pursuing real transformation agenda for their tertiary institutions, we are in Ghana debating and putting in manifesto change of names of universities. How does change of names

of universities add to our gross tertiary enrolment ratio? How does change of names of universities contribute to shaping universities that will be able to produce graduates that can compete competently in any part of the world for opportunities? How can dishonouring S. D. Dombo and dishonouring C. K Tedom add to the number of graduates that will have productive skills that will be produced from the four walls of our universities? In our 21st century today, the House of Parliament must be engaged in intellectual legislations that will rather propel this country on the map. If we look at all the countries who are on the top of tertiary education in the world, United States of America with gross tertiary enrolment ratio of 88 per cent, United Kingdom (UK) gross tertiary enrolment ratio of 81 per cent, Germany, 77 per cent. Even the highest in Africa is Mauritius, 44 per cent. Check the history of the nomenclature of their universities and you will find out that for as long as 180 years, Stanford University, Harvard University, St. Andrews University, one of the oldest in the UK, Anglia Ruskin University, Heriott-Watt University, Leeds University, Brown University, named after Nicholas Brown— All these notable universities over centuries have maintained their names. But we are in Ghana and we are competing over which political party must change the names of universities.

Mr Speaker, the politicisation of the names of universities will not add anything to the relevance and the quality of tertiary education. The nations we are competing with do not care about change of names. They are minded about

maintaining the names they came to meet. Previous governments came to meet names that have been assigned to universities to honour the memories of great heroes, they maintain it.

For anything at all, they have other heroes yet unsung, so they create opportunities to be able to honour those heroes. Here, we are taking a Motion. Rather very shamefully, we are removing C. K. Tedom from the university and now the new name is University of Technology and Applied Sciences, Navrongo and that is what we are excited about. We on this Side will not be part of this shameful act of dishonouring the memories of our heroes. We are opposing this rather unpatriotic act and urging our friends to withdraw this Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Ntim Fordjour, can you withdraw the word shameful act?

Rev Ntim Fordjour: Mr Speaker, I am guided and I withdraw and I replace it with this unpatriotic act. It is unproductive and non-progressive in the 21st century. When we took the gross tertiary enrolment ratio of Ghana from 16 per cent in 2016, we managed to expand access to tertiary education to 23 per cent in 2024. They are expected to take it from 24 per cent to a minimum of 40 per cent as part of the education strategic plan. That is what they must pursue. That is what must occupy their priorities. This change of name at a time when Parliaments are legislating Artificial Intelligence (AI), legislation that provides framework for the deployment of ethical AI in tertiary institutions for research and for assessment.

2:20 p.m.

We are here, busy prioritising the change of names. How did we get here in the first place? We got here because a group of people sat down, and instead of putting a transformative vision in their Manifesto, what mattered to them is change of the names of universities. That is what they put in their Manifestos, and that is what they are pursuing. They do not care about deploying AI infrastructure for tertiary institutions. They do not care about deploying Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) into institutions. They do not care about linking industry to the lecture room, to ensure that children and young learners, or young university students by the age of 18 or 19, are able to have adequate and ample experience in notable industries; elsewhere, in jurisdictions where they are not really minded about the change of names. We are here and not minded about how our learners who are watching us from the Gallery, the skills they will obtain from schools, and the lifelong learning skills they will obtain from universities. We still produce graduates from this Country, and industries will have to train them for three to four years.

Mr Speaker, this House must rather engage in forward-looking legislation, and not legislation that dishonours our past heroes; today is a very sad one. We are insulting the memories of C. K. Tedam, S. D. Dombo, and how is that going to be an inspiration for Mr Haruna Iddrisu or for Mr Bernard Ahiafor, to be able to contribute immensely such that, even after hundreds of years when he has

exited this earth, his monuments and his footprints will be recognised by future generations by way of naming a university or a research centre after such notable individuals. This act will not be a good act for this Government, or for this country. It would not augur well for posterity, and I humbly urge that this House stands down this Bill, because of tomorrow. What example are we demonstrating? We are expecting the Ministry of Education and the National Democratic Congress (NDC) Government should rather come and ask us how the House could support them with legislative framework that will ensure that C. K. Tedam University of Technology and Applied Sciences can invent drones, ships, or software that will be able to support Mr Sam George in fighting cybercrime. That is the kind of request we urge them to bring, so that we support them, and not change of names. This will be one of the most unintellectual legislations to be passed if we support it.

Mr Speaker, therefore, we appeal —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Ntim Fordjour?

Rev Fordjour: Mr Speaker?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You are not a fresh Member of this House. You know the rules that we do not use a language in a very insulting manner.

Rev Fordjour: “Unintellectual” is insulting?

Mr Speaker, I am guided. I take a cue.

Mr Speaker, in your magnanimity, in your wisdom, we all take a cue, and I am guided by that, and that is why we need to lead this Country in the right way. The young children are watching, everybody in the education sector is watching, our development partners are watching, and our university professors are watching. The House may become a laughing stock if we demonstrate that what matters to us is not how we pass AI legislation. When was the last time this House passed an AI legislation for our tertiary institution? When was the last time this House passed a framework to support —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are now sounding repetitive, so conclude.

Rev Fordjour: So, in conclusion, Mr Speaker, we must stand down this legislation. We must honour the memories of our heroes, and rather pursue expansionary legislation that will ensure that we expand the existing universities and tertiary institutions we have, and not just adding new names, changing names, or building new small universities and then claim we are building new universities, and then political parties will now have to be competing on how many universities they constructed and how many names they changed. But just as we benchmark global best practices, when was the last time a new university was set up in America, the United Kingdom (UK) or Germany? But they are expanding the existing ones. They are expanding Harvard and the University of Southern California. What they do is that they extend branches to other States and other

Cities to expand access and bring affordable, quality and relevant tertiary education to the doorstep of ordinary Ghanaians; that is what this House must be engaged in.

So, if this House will be minded, respectfully, and if the Minister for Education will be minded, we understand it was a manifesto promise. But this is a House of Parliament, and we owe the good people of Ghana the solemn responsibility to do the right things and to enact legislation that future generations will benefit from. We do not see any justification or benefit from the report on how the Ghanaians will benefit from the change of name.

The Ministry and the Committee failed to justify the benefits that our students in C. K. Tedam University of Technology and Applied Sciences will benefit from a mere change of name. They should bring legislation that will ensure innovative financing of tertiary education beyond no fee stress. We want innovative and sustainable financing schemes, and we will support them to pass those Bills. We will support them to pass Bills that will enhance the capacity of our faculty members and foster partnerships that are productive.

With these words, I believe that we will stand this down and rather think about more forward-looking legislation to support our education transformation agenda.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs?

Mr Ahmed Ibrahim (NDC — Banda) : Mr Speaker, thank you for giving me the opportunity to support the Motion on the floor.

Mr Speaker, the records must be set straight, and I remember we were all here when one fateful midnight, in this Chamber, these name changes were done in this House.

Mr Speaker, who is a hero? A hero is an achiever. Heroes are not named after what somebody has achieved; is that heroism? No. What are we doing? For over 50 years, all the universities in Ghana were concentrated in the south. It took former President Rawlings to use his personal donation to establish the University for Development Studies in Tamale.

Mr Speaker, when Professor Mills' Government came in 2009, and the Board of the University wanted the university to be named after former President Rawlings, the former President Rawlings, whose personal donation was used to establish that university, refused.

Mr Speaker, and besides that, with the University for Development Studies, the core belief of President Rawlings was that the northern sector must develop, and the entire Ghana must develop, and therefore, the name of that university must be University for Development Studies.

Mr Speaker, who says names have no meaning? I am surprised, my brother, he and I are Pastors. I am an Elder, and he is a Pastor. We believe that names have meanings. Why would he not name his son Judas Iscariot? If names have no meaning, he should name his son after Judas Iscariot. Names have meanings, and that is why names are chosen carefully.

Mr Speaker, former President Rawlings, did not just say that the University for Development Studies should not be named after him. It was named University for Development Studies for a specific reason, and that university is living its name. The contribution and impact of University for Development Studies from 2000 to date is unimaginable.

2:30 p.m.

Mr Speaker, it is that university that has opened up the entire north. From Tamale, it went to Wa and Navrongo. Then the National Democratic Congress (NDC) government lost power, then the New Patriotic Party (NPP) came and they decided to rename the branches. Were they voted to do outdoorings?

But, Mr Speaker, if we read the Report of the Committee of Education, the basis for the proposed name change, Mr Speaker, for your permission, I read just a small portion of it, page 4 of the report “The proposed renaming of the institution is presented as part of a broader effort to align with international best practises while promoting national unity.” Are we now saying we should

depart from best practises? Should we depart from national unity? Mr Speaker, the report is self-explanatory, and the Committee unanimously recommended this for our approval. So, what are we saying?

So, Mr Speaker, without mincing words, we must depart from that aspect of renaming and redoing things that are already there. Do we remember the day that we were inaugurating that university in Navrongo? People had to run for their lives. There was a great wind that took all the canopies. All the big men were running for their lives. We know all this. We were all there. So, the protest did not even only begin from here. When we told them that we brought UDS, Nyankpala, and Navrongo campuses to open up the north, they should have added something. There is Damongo and Nalerigu and other regional capitals. There is also Yendi. They chose not to bring anything new, but to go and rename them and do outdoorings.

So, Mr Speaker, I want to commend the distinguished Minister for Education, who was then the Minority Leader and brought superior advice, which was not heeded to. The needful must be done. If there were mistakes, they must be corrected. We should not say that names have no impact. We know the impact of Navrongo Senior High School, and this technology university will be added. The north is going digital.

On that note, Mr Speaker, I end my case here, and call on my Brothers on the other Side to wholeheartedly support this Motion. Mr Speaker, if it will bring

national unity, toe the line of best practises, and build its core value for technology, I so support. Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth (NPP—Okere): Thank you, Mr Speaker. Today is indeed a very sad day. It is mostly significant because we have very young boys and girls in the gallery, and I am looking at them.

Mr Speaker, when we were young, we were asked to pick role models and aspire to be like high-achieving individuals. I have a lot of respect for my Minister, but in all deference to him, is he telling me that C. K. Tedom was not an achiever? Is he telling me that the naming of the university after C. K. Tedom is bringing disunity? Does he have any shred of evidence to prove that the naming of this University and institution, as the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs said, brought disunity?

I hold in my hands the Constitution of the Republic of Ghana and I want to read Article 35, which is under the Directive Principle of State Policy. Article 35(9) says, “The state shall promote among the people of Ghana the culture of political tolerance.” This is enshrined in the Constitution of the Republic of Ghana. The framers of this Constitution knew very well that one of the things that will bring us together is to tolerate each other. Apart from religion and ethnicity, political tolerance is also important. For me it is not a matter of the Minister, it is Government’s Business, and this was a political promise. Not all

political promises have seen the day of light, especially when it is revealed.

Mr Speaker, we are talking about C. K. Tedom, a man who lived to be 94 years old, full of wisdom and a very calm man. A man who had been a Minister and Member of Parliament and served at the highest stage as a member of the Council of State. A man who represented calmness. This is a man that anybody from the North must emulate. It is unfortunate that they seek to indicate something by asking Rev Ntim Fordjour whether he would name his son after Judas Iscariot. That is a very unfortunate statement. Because of the representation of what Judas Iscariot means, are we telling ourselves that S. D. Dombo, C. K. Tedom and Appiah-Menka are Judas Iscariots? Can we imagine? Is that what we want to portray?

Mr Speaker, a lot of times when I talk, I speak as a young man and a person who aspires to serve our nation. When we talk about resetting, the impression is that we want to change the ills of governance. I believe we improve upon ourselves. Is this the changing of the ills of governance? Can we not tolerate each other for once? A lot of times we talk about collaboration. When we want to do government business and progress this nation, we should see that both Sides come together to push things that are good for the good of the young people of this country.

But I would make a passionate appeal to all of us here, particularly those on the Majority Side, that there are some things that take us back. When one steps on

somebody's toe deliberately, that person is tempted to do the same, and Ghana will be the loser. When political parties change government, they try to undo each other and do the very things that we complain about to each other, and Ghana is their biggest loser. I want to make this passionate appeal, because for me, this is not the way to go. It does not encourage unity or political tolerance, and it is a brute show of force of majority.

I have said this before and I want to repeat, that Ghanaians gave overwhelming majority to them and God knows the reason. God gave an opportunity for us to do things smoothly. Once we are committed to doing it, we have the numbers to do it and we must do things the right way. The Minister knows that I admire him so much. We have all seen his exploits. I believe that we can rethink, look into our conscience and see that these people are achievers.

We named the stadium after Baba Yara and I do not think that was wrong. We have not been able to name all sports facilities after sportsmen. Definitely, if somebody refuses to accept an honour, he may have personal reasons, but it does not mean that another person should not be honoured. What we are doing is the highest form of political intolerance, and it is a line we must never cross. Because once we do this, families, emotions and spirits involved, and I believe in our ancestors. The ancestors are watching.

Mr Speaker, in my culture, when somebody grows and lives long, he gets closer to the ancestors. It is believed that when the elderly speak, the ancestors

listen because they are closer. Why are we doing this to a man that lived to be 94 years old? For what? Because of political intolerance or to get at each other? What do we achieve by doing this? I would personally appeal that we take a look at this Bill again.

2:40 p.m.

We all have conscience. Looking at our faces, I know that we believe deep down that left to us, we would not push this, because, as I said, these are achievers. These are people who have served the State and the nation, and I do not think that we should do this. By doing this, we would be showing the highest form of political intolerance, and that will also help to promote some of these things that repeat themselves, so that when a government comes, they would want to get back at each other, and Ghana will be the biggest loser. My brothers and sisters, the very young ones will be the biggest losers.

Ghanaians will have to spend their precious time today— With all the agenda I see on the *Order Paper*, we are spending and dedicating time today debating because we want to show political force.

Mr Speaker, as I conclude, I want to make this passionate appeal to all of us as Members of Parliament, the Bill has been brought before us to consider, and I want us to search our hearts, souls, and conscience to see whether this is something we must do to mother Ghana and the memories of these people.

Thank you very much.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Yes, Mr Speaker, may I thank Hon Members —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minister, let me find out whether the Leadership of the Minority wants to contribute, then you will conclude.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: We have two more contributors from our Side; one Hon Member and myself.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, before you came, there was an agreement that three Members from each Side, including Leadership. So, I have taken two. That is why I am offering the opportunity to—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Minority Chief Whip told me that. But he spoke to his Colleague on the other Side, and I was under the impression that because of the discussion he had, you had been put on notice. That is why I was able to —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, I am not aware. Has there been a change in the arrangement?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: He spoke to the Majority Chief Whip and that is the point. If it has not been communicated, then that is fair enough.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, nothing has changed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leadership?

Minority Leader (Osahen Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, the Hon Member for Okere, who just resumed his seat, has made my day. The Hon Rev Ntim Fordjour, who also spoke before him, has made my day. They have spoken wisdom. They have drawn our attention as a nation to matters that are rather more relevant and are supposed to be prioritised.

Mr Speaker, perhaps for emphasis, let me, at the risk of being repetitive, re-echo Article 35(9), which was earlier quoted by the respected Member for Okere. It quotes: “The state shall promote among the people of Ghana the culture of political tolerance.”

Mr Speaker, I have said time without number that this Ninth Parliament and this new administration must work together to end that vicious cycle of “you-do-me I-do-you”. Mr Speaker, I have said this in this Chamber, and I am repeating it for the umpteenth time. Sometimes, I feel so proud of myself. I feel proud because when NPP was in power, and certain things were happening to some of our Friends across, I was among the few who worked so hard day and night to ensure that the temperature was cooled down. I am proud. That is why today I can look into the eyes of some of my Colleagues in Government and remind them that only yesterday, *na nipa ye mɔbo, na nipa ense hwee*. Colleagues, what we are doing to ourselves and the impression we are creating out there will not help the cause of democracy in this country.

I agree, and I will not pretend every government comes with its excesses. The

Akufo-Addo’s administration, Kufuor’s administration, Rawlings’ administration, and Atta Mills’ administration all had their good sides but also made some mistakes. The question is, at what point are we going to end this era of vengeance? Mr Speaker, at what point are we going to end this thing called you did it to me, I am also doing it to you, to settle the scores. Then it would continue without an end.

Mr Speaker, it was December 2024 when we had the election. On the 7th of December, within hours of the election, we knew who the winner was. All too soon, a year has passed. I know it is natural to expect that our Friends opposite expect that in the next election, they would win. Even in the next election after that, they expect that they should be winning perpetually. It is natural. It is their party. They would not go into an election expecting to lose. But we are dealing with a creature called democracy. The very people who vote for me today are the same very people who will say, “no” tomorrow because of disappointment in one way or the other. Sometimes, our inability to pay for somebody’s outdooing will lead to our exit from this Chamber. Somebody has gone to give birth, but the outdooing we could not contribute. Funeral, we could not contribute. Somebody’s school fees we could not pay, So, *me nto ma wo*. To wit, I would not vote for you. These are the things we experience.

If as political leaders, we cannot congregate around a table and agree on key national issues and each day it is a partisan call, I am afraid we will not get

anywhere. So, I am not ashamed being in opposition. I am not. I am rather proud that in times of their peril, some of my Colleagues and I were there for them because we understood the basic practice of democracy.

Mr Speaker, let me make the point. I am saying this because a law has been enacted today. The whole essence of this Bill, the time we are spending to argue here, is basically for the purposes of changing the name of a university.

Mr Speaker — *[Interruption]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, you are still on the floor.

Osahen Afenyo- Markin: Mr Speaker, all we are doing is to just change the name, and we are changing the name to what? When the word “patriotism” is used, it must be understood in a broader sense that, at any level, if we serve our nation, we will be honoured.

2:50 p.m.

Mr Speaker, at any stage in one’s life, something must inspire one to be of service to one’s nation, that we should do things that will inspire our citizenry to engage in public service, and public service is at all levels, not only being a political leader. So, we cannot continue to do this to ourselves because we make political promises.

Mr Speaker, the Constitution is clear, but I am surprised that the justification is that changing the name is to promote national cohesion. Promoting national

cohesion by changing the name of a university? Which name is to inspire the young ones? Which name is to honour the heroism of the character who has been honoured? I am yet to hear from our Colleagues opposite regarding anything about the person who was honoured, whether or not he was involved in any crime, whether he had done anything. We cannot continue to do this.

I would want to make an appeal to the respected Minister for Education. I know at Cabinet, issues come up. But I also know, because I have been there before, that those who feel strongly about certain matters are able to wage persuasive arguments. Even long after Cabinet meeting, they will still approach the President and still make a point, that Mr President, this one, I think, in the interest of the nation, let us depart. This is just a moral appeal I am making to the respected Hon Haruna Iddrisu. Because in the end, the thing is done, but the record will have it long after we have left this Chamber that it was under his signature that this was done. I do not think that these majoritarian imposing views, that it is the decision of the Majority and nothing more, would help.

Mr Speaker, I would want to conclude with a reminder. In the 8th Parliament, there came a time that I needed the assistance of our Friends in the Minority. We all know the numbers, 137 Members on the Minority Side and 137 on the Majority Side. At a point that the discussions got to a certain level and we needed a breakthrough, I was reminded that when we had 169 Members, our Side in Leadership was

not ready to listen at all. I was reminded that human beings do not forget. I was told that, Leader, we wish we can do this, but we are referring you to the 7th Parliament, that when you had 169 Members, there were things that our Side, referring to the NDC Side, said that were ignored. Therefore, with the numbers at par, I should not expect extra support. Indeed, I did not get what I wanted. I am using this to remind my Colleagues that we are 87 today, and they are 189, but in three years, we all know there will be elections, and we cannot predict how the numbers will look. But what I know—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, do not forget the fact that we are at the Second Reading of a Bill, and Order 127 is very clear, that the basis of the debate is the explanatory memorandum and the Report of the Committee.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I thank you for your continuous guidance but I would plead with you to hear me in context. I am dealing with the memorandum accompanying the Bill, as well as the Report of the Committee.

The main argument here has to do with the change of name. In making an appeal to the other Side to abandon this legislation, I need to give instances. So that submission was to corroborate. I was trying to make a point and to draw the attention that as we are here, there are decisions that they may want to take, that they find it desirable, but those decisions may not be prudent. That is why I use my own example when I was the Leader,

when it got to a point, I was reminded of happenings that had taken place before my leadership in the Seventh Parliament. And I am using that—Mr Speaker, let me land with respect.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority leader, is there anything in the explanatory memorandum as well as the Report that talks about Majority and Minority?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, let me finish.

I am reminding my Colleagues that if today they decide not to listen to us, they may not be too sure because Ghana's democracy is not coming to an end. This is what we have chosen for ourselves as a people. We have an election ahead and we do not know what the outcome may be. So let us act in a manner that it would even become an equity for negotiation to build consensus tomorrow. Our Friends should not just look at today, but they should look at tomorrow.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, conclude.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: I would plead with them that merely coming in to do this is not the best.

Mr Speaker, that said, I shall conclude by saying that the records should reflect that this Report is a Majority decision Report because our Members on the Committee indicated that this report is a Majority Report. It was rushed. As soon as they brought it, they rushed it. The notice that was given

was just some 30-minute notice, but we do not want to litigate it. They say they are in Majority. They have the numbers at the Committee, but we do not want them to go further to say that this is a consensus report. No, it is not a report by consensus; it is the same thing for the C. K. Tedom—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, is it expressly stated in the report that it is a Majority decision Report?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I have read it. He said when Hon Ahmed Ibrahim spoke, he said it was a unanimous decision Report. What I want to say is that, just for the avoidance of doubt, that phrase does not come out. So, we want, for the avoidance of doubt, to bring clarity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, you can guide the House. What is the phrase in the Report?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the phrase does not state that it is a Majority decision Report. So, we want it to reflect as such, that it is a Majority decision. We made it clear to them. Even the notice given for the meeting, we just do not want to pursue it. They gave notice in less than 30 minutes and convened a meeting. But we do not want to go there. We just want to go by the principle that indeed, this was a meeting of themselves; it is their Majority decision. We cannot question them. After all, we move here with majority decisions, so it is all right. But let there be clarity, that it is a Majority decision.

That is all. They can proceed to do what they want to do.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

3:00 p.m.

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu) (MP): Mr Speaker, let me conclude by thanking our Colleagues and to further assure them that university names are strategic academic assets that embody historical continuity, reputational capital, and international recognition. Abrupt or politically motivated renaming risks eroding the institutional legacy, disrupting alumni networks, and weakening global visibility and diminishing public trust.

Mr Speaker, I heard the argument of the Hon Member for Okere, Daniel Addo-Kenneth. While I respect his reference to the Constitution, I want us, including the Minority Leader, to learn and let me use this opportunity to assure this august House that President John Dramani Mahama intends to reset Ghana and its governance and to use his majority of 189 for a purposeful strengthening of Ghana's administrative and constitutional structures.

Hon Addo-Kenneth should know that he who seeks equity must do equity. When they were renaming those universities: C. K. Tedom and SD Dombo. What happened to Abeifaa Karbo? Jatoe Kaleo, what happened to him? L. R. Abavana, what happened to him? They were not naming Kojo Botsio or K. A. Gbedema or Kofi Baako, but I take a good value from his argument.

Political tolerance, were they tolerant at that hour? They were not. It was one-sided. So, today I learned a lesson: when one preaches political tolerance, one who seeks equity must do equity. He who comes to equity must come with clean hands. At the time, they were one-sided; they did not take the nation along. But I am guided by your advice.

Mr Speaker, to assure our Colleagues again, I have given them names: Abeifaa Karbo, Jatoe Kaleo and Abavana. Perhaps, they share the same philosophical and political thinking. But those were not the names he recognised. Believe me sincerely, that President John Dramani Mahama received a number of petitions in protest against the naming. Also, to put it simply, there were names before they were changed. So, let us not argue as if I am coming just fresh. The Universities had names, and they changed the names. We are changing it back to the original names.

Now, to the Minority Leader. I cherish his argument, and I have always advocated, if he remembers even my comment, when he said that in a democracy, compromise is essential. I am a true advocate of it. He would recall that even when we asked him to censure Ken Ofori-Atta, I made persuasive gestures to him and his Side to save the Ghanaian economy and this country. If he reasoned with me at the time, he would have been guided to save this country. He said I was in the Minority. Today, even President Akufo-Addo may probably be disappointed, if for nothing, for getting Ghana into a debt exchange.

But at the time, we wanted to be nationalistic. We kept advising that the way he was going; he was likely to crash the Minority. He thought it was opposition talk. It is not all his comments that I take with a pinch of salt. Believe me, even yesterday, I was reading about the significant strife he had made in building libraries and naming them after people. I appreciate him for that. But on this, Mr Speaker, we are renaming to keep, as I said, the unity of the country.

President Mahama will not use his majority in Parliament to settle petty political scores. I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I urge you not put the Question. I come under Article 104 of the 1992 Constitution, which reads, “Except as otherwise provided in the Constitution, matters in Parliament—”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You cannot urge me not to put a question.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: All right. Mr Speaker, I am drawing your attention—

Question put and Motion agreed to.

C. K. Tedam University of Technology and Applied Sciences (Amendment) Bill, 2025, accordingly read a Second time.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Habib.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I come under Order 151(3), and with your permission, I read:

“A Member may challenge the decision of the Speaker on the voice vote and the Speaker shall determine whether to call for headcount or electronic vote.”

Mr Speaker, I was on my feet to draw your attention to Article 104 of the Constitution, which states that decisions in Parliament shall be taken by at least half of Members of Parliament present, which is 138. The Supreme Court took this decision in *Justice Abdulai v. the Attorney-General*. That is why I am challenging this decision. We do not have the requisite number to pass all these important rules.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib, you read the rules clearly that the Speaker shall determine whether there should be a division.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: No, it says that the Speaker shall determine whether to call for a headcount or an electronic vote. Either headcount or electronic vote, these are the options you have.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib, kindly resume your seat. Yes, Majority Leader, any indication?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I know my Friend, the Deputy Minority Whip, knows very well that we have a quorum. The quorum is not only the people on this Side. The quorum is everybody in this Chamber. Unless he walks his Members out, if we do a headcount now, he will find out that we have a quorum. I just want to indicate that I know this is a politically charged matter, and I know

the implications for the New Patriotic Party (NPP) political tradition for these changes that are taking place now. I can understand and appreciate their opposition to these changes that we are making now.

But quorum is presumed, and when he raises the issue to challenge the voice vote. The Speaker knows what to do. So, let us allow the Speaker to go through the processes. I think that is what the Speaker wanted to draw your attention to. The Speaker will give an indication what he wants to do. So let us allow the Speaker to go through the processes. The Speaker will give an indication what he wants to do. If they have further issues that they want to raise, they can do so.

But I can assure them that they may resist as they can, but the names will be changed today. The names will be changed today, no matter what it will take to change the names, we will do it; we will change the names today. So, they can put up an appearance of resistance, and we will appreciate that. But the names will be changed today. In fact, the decision to change the names took place long ago. There has just been a delay in getting the Bills to come here. Once the Bills are here, I am a 100 per cent sure I have the numbers. They just stepped out because it is time for Friday prayers. Some have returned, and others have also stepped out to have lunch.

If they want the numbers, I will take a short suspension, and I will ensure that this Chamber is full. We will take these Bills and change the names today.

So, they better allow us to go through the process, change the names, and then we can adjourn early so everybody will have enough time to travel to their constituencies, or they can drag it and we will still change the names, and we will change it today.

Mr Speaker, those are my indications.

3:10 p.m.

And I will make sure the Chamber is full, and we will take this Bills and change the names today. They better allow us to through the process, change the names, so we can adjourn early. Everybody will have enough time to travel to their constituencies

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am not abandoning my intention of drawing your attention to the absence of decision-making quorum. As much as the Hon Majority Leader might think that he has the numbers, the numbers in this sense is when they are present at the time of taking the decision. At the time we were taking the decision, we were 85 in the Chamber. *[Uproar]* We need 138 Members to take that decision. I still invite Mr Speaker to do the right thing.

Mr Speaker, if you so establish that we are 138 in this Chamber, I will rest my case. But, as we sit, at a glance, including this Side, we are not up to 138 Members. So, the Motion to change—I am very surprised the Majority Leader is saying that the decision is already made. Hon Majority Leader as a Northerner, Minister for Education as a Northerner, the President as a Northerner, they want

to remove their own brother, S. D. Dombo's name. They want to remove his name. We will not stand for this.

Mr Speaker, I yield to you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib, let me offer a free advice to you. When you want to raise an issue, raise it properly. I would urge you to approach the Hon Minority Leader; he will tell you what exactly you should place on record.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib, I called on the Majority Leader.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, in his response, he indicated that the name that is being changed, C. K. Tedom, is a northerner's name, and the Minister for Education, the President, John Dramani Mahama and I, who are northerners, are trying to remove the name of a northerner and reverse it to what it was. The person who sent the university there is not a northerner. The person who sent the university there, the former President Jerry John Rawlings, sacrificed his personal money which was a global award that was given to him. Many of us would have used that money to buy a Mercedes Maybach, and drive it around for our own comfort. The Former President, Jerry John Rawlings did not buy a Maybach. He chose to use the money to invest in the establishment of a university for the people of the north. He chose to call it University for Development Studies. Why would

someone who has sacrificed his personal money establish a university—When even the university wanted to change the name so that it would be called Jerry John Rawlings University, he said no. He wanted the university to remain the name that he gave it, University for Development Studies (UDS). Mr Speaker, why did he name it Development Studies? Because he appreciated that first and foremost, what the north needed was development. So, he was creating a university focusing on the study of how to develop. He recommended a model of university programme that would engender development. The programme was an integrated studies programme where the students lived in the community and studied in the community, and were instructed by their lecturers in the community. A unique model of development studies.

After he succeeded in doing that, the NPP administration comes to change the name when they have not built a university. They have not built a university for the people in the north. Yet they wake up one early morning and then they decide that they are going to change it. I am told it was midnight. *[Laughter]* One midnight, nicodemously, when we were all asleep, they gave instructions that the name should be changed to somebody that we all know the person's political and traditional allegiance. They wanted a name from the Upper East. Mr Speaker, I was there, and my name could have been used. *[Laughter]* As a northern leader, my name could have also been used. Mr Cletus Avoka is there. His name could have been used. Of all the northern leaders that were there, why

did they not pick one of us? Why did it have to be that person? The Yaa Naa is there. The great king of Mamprugu is there. The Bawku Naba is there. The Navro-Pio is there. These great leaders of the north were all there. Why him?

Mr Speaker, one of the greatest leaders of the north, Alhaji Mahama Iddrisu, was there. Why was it not Dr Sulley Gariba? Why not Prof John Sebiyam Nabila of blessed memory? Mr Speaker, they cannot incite the north against me. Because if they go and conduct polls in the north, all the people will tell them to reverse the name to what it was. Because they did not consult the northern people when they were changing the names. They did not consult them. Mr Speaker, I take objection to his attempt to incite the people of the north against me. They should go and build their own university and they can name it whatever they want and none of us will challenge it. *[Hear! Hear!]*

I know as I speak, they are attempting to deplete the Chamber of their Members. It will not change anything. We will invite the Members in, and we will change the name today as I have indicated. Mr Speaker knows what to do. If he is challenging the voice, Mr Speaker can put the voice vote again and then take a decision. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I stand by my action of drawing Mr Speaker's attention to the absence of a decision-making quorum. Having taken into consideration what is happening, we are still not even 138. I still stand by it.

Mr Speaker, apply the rule on a head count to establish the number of whether we are 138 or not.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon First Deputy Minority Whip, we have passed that particular stage and I think we should be looking at the Motion numbered 34.

BILL — SECOND READING

Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That the Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025 be now read a Second time.

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Peter Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025 accordingly read a Second time.

3:20 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, there was an application challenging the voice vote. With respect, he made two applications; one was on the absence of a decision-making quorum. The *Hansard* has it; he went ahead and even the voice vote, he was challenging it and he quoted the Standing Orders. So it cannot be that you would say that we have moved past the stage of we not having a decision-making quorum.

Mr Speaker, the applicant still went ahead to pray, in terms of questioning the voice vote. With respect, we are all here to cooperate and give respect to one another. The application he made is valid. He quoted the Standing Orders. Please, he is challenging the voice vote. It cannot be that it is too late in the day. He was timeous; he rose up on his feet as soon as you announced—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, with all due respect, I was clear in my mind. That was the reason for which I asked the First Deputy Minority Whip, to get in touch with you as to how to raise the quorum.

Hon Members, if you are raising a quorum regarding a decision-making, it is different from you calling for a division. You cannot put the two together. The records would bear me out that it is on that basis that I indicated and placed on record that the first Deputy Minority Whip, should approach the Minority Leader as to how to raise the quorum. So, I was not clear on whether they were calling for a division or drawing my attention to a decision-making Quorum. So, if you are

indicating that a quorum has been raised, Minority Leader, I think the record will bear us all. Why would I be asking him to see you as to how to raise the quorum for my consideration in the circumstances? Did I not say so? What circumstances?

So, Hon Members, let us get things right and do things right. If you want to invoke the Standing Order, do so properly. If you want to invoke the Constitution, do so and that is why I am saying that the quorum having not being properly raised, I moved on. I would not go on a reverse gear. So, if you have something else to say, you can say so.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, Parliament is a House of record. I want to take you through what I did. When you were about to put the Question, I was on my feet and I quoted Article 104 of the 1992 Constitution to tell you the absence of a decision-making quorum.

Mr Speaker, you went ahead to put the Question and thereafter, I now quoted our Standing order 151(3), to challenge your decision on the voice vote. The right thing to do under Order 151(3) which gives you two options, that is either to call for electronic votes or a headcount. Therefore, I am repeating my application, to challenge your decision on the voice vote, coming under Order 151(3), calling for a headcount.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, it is important for Members to

understand the relationship between our Constitution and the Standing Orders. One cannot go straight and raise an objection to anything on the basis of the Constitution. One would have to start from the Standing Orders. Because it is the Standing Orders that govern the processes in this House. Where there is a Constitutional Provision, the Standing Orders then incorporate that constitutional provision into the Standing Orders. What is the procedure?

Mr Speaker, the procedure is simple. There is a presumption of quorum at all times, unless raised. Three people can be in this Chamber and they would take a decision and it will be binding, unless there is evidence that there was no quorum to start business. At the beginning of the Business of the day, when we go and take the *Votes and Proceedings*, what does it record as those who attended the Sitting of Parliament that day? That is what is used to determine whether that day there was a quorum. But during the Sitting, people may step out of the Chamber. So, one can raise a question of quorum at any moment. Even quorum to sit as a House and one to take a decision.

They have not raised an issue of quorum. There was a vote. In fact, when we were deliberating the matter, they knew that at the end of the deliberation, we were going to put the Question and vote on it. So, if at the time that we were deliberating, they perceived that there was no quorum, they should have raised a quorum at that time. Then, the Speaker would be conscious that there is a question of quorum, therefore, he should

not even put a Question unless he determines that there is a quorum. You did not raise any question of quorum.

Now, when we got to putting the Question—the Speaker put the Question and then there was a voice vote. At that point, he could not get up and raise a question of quorum. What he ought to have done was to challenge the voice vote. When he challenges the voice vote, then they call for a head count. When they call for a head count, it would now reveal the absence of a decision-making quorum. But they did not do all that.

Now, the Speaker has put the Question, we have voted and they are raising a constitutional issue about a decision-making quorum. The Speaker is seeking to direct them to show them that this is not how they ought to have come.

Mr Speaker, I think we are finished with this matter. If he wants to raise a question of quorum, let him raise a question of quorum. When he raises a question of quorum, then we can ring the bell, wait for 10 minutes and then determine whether we have a quorum or not. If after 10 minutes, we ring the bell and count—*[Interruption]*

Mr Speaker, it is obvious that we have a quorum.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Order! Order!

Hon Minority Leader, the truth be told, when the First Deputy Minority Whip got up on his feet, what he was asking me to do, Hon Members, would

be very unconstitutional. He was calling on me to interpret Article 104 of the Constitution, which is an exclusive preserve of the Supreme Court. So, what the Hon Member should have done was to raise quorum and then Order 64, will guide all of us. That is what we would have done. I would have ordered the bell to be rung.

3:30 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: I think we have to make progress.

Mr Speaker, equity has always looked at substance. Where the form conflicts with substance, form gives way to substance. The application for the avoidance of doubt is anchored on order 151. I know that the Majority Leader decided to engage in a long lecture of filibustering to get his Whips, who are busy all over, to call Members in. We know what he was doing.

Mr Speaker, we know what he was doing; repeating and repeating himself. He has now taken upon himself the role of the chief filibuster of the Parliament of Ghana. So, he was just filibustering to get their Whips to get their people in. Now we can see what Hon Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe is doing. She is marking absenteeism with her camera. She takes pictures of those who do not come for punitive action. What she has forgotten is that *nkorɔfoɔ erebreɛ*, to wit, people are suffering. Instead of taking pictures and seeking to punish them, motivate them and let them come in. Some of them do not have Committees. Some of them do not have money to go to the

constituency. She cannot use a camera to intimidate her people to come in. They would not come. She cannot threaten them. Somebody is chopping big, somebody is hungry. They are hungry. Their Members are hungry and they want them to come. The picture will not work. What they are doing will not work.

Mr Speaker, we now see the First Deputy Majority Whip taking pictures for punishment. They would not come. Cameras will capture Hon Doyoe trying to take pictures of Backbenchers who are not here so that they are punished. They cannot punish them. Give them jobs. Motivate them. They cannot go to their constituency. That is what you should do. Some people are enjoying, others are not enjoying and you expect them to come. They would not come and they cannot be threatened.

Mr Speaker, the application is for a headcount or we go into Division. That is what the rule says. We know that the Majority Leader will filibuster when it pleases him. Yesterday, when he was supposed to debate on Appropriation, he said he would not debate and would leave everything to Dr Forson —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Headcount on which of the Motions?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, on Order 151. He has made the application already.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Which Motion? We have taken the Motion numbered 34. We are proceeding to the Consideration Stage.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, With respect, no.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is it the procedural Motion?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, let us solve it. No. The decision on the Second Reading is what was challenged.

Mr Speaker, let us end it peacefully. I am pleading with you. He wants to come and filibuster again because he knows the numbers are not up to. We have challenged the decision on the consideration for the Second Reading. That is what we are challenging. The voice vote did not carry the day. We are saying that the voice vote did not carry the day. Therefore, let us go into headcount. So that there will be clarity.

Mr Speaker, the more you delay, the more you seek to undermine our application. As we delay, they come in. All of them will participate in the headcount because when we were taking the earlier voice vote, about 50 of them were not here.

Mr Speaker, I know those who were here. Now, if you eventually order for the headcount, they would all participate all because the First Deputy Majority Whip has now used her camera to take pictures. We do not know where she is taking the pictures to. The solution is to give them an appointment. They are hungry. *Hɔmɔ mli ye aɛ, mo ko nye ni, mo ko hu hɔmɔ mli ye aɛ.* The solution is to give them appointments, they are hungry, *hɔmɔ mli ye aɛ, mo ko nye ni, mo ko hu hɔmɔ mli ye aɛ. O le? Mi nkɛ o le?*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Doyoe, your name has been mentioned. Let me hear you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: *Amɛ ba a, o webi amɛ ba a*, they would not come. Your Backbench are hungry. They are hungry. Go and take care of them. Some people have four boards while others do not have a board at all and you want them to come? They would not come. *Amɛ ba a*.

Mr Speaker, let us take a headcount.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I am surprised that yesterday, I decided to spare my younger brother and Minority Leader, the agony of debating him. Instead of thanking me for not debating him yesterday, today, he is raising it as if I was afraid of him yesterday.

Mr Speaker, yesterday, I said I will not debate him because he said that he did not do Mathematics. Mr Speaker, Mathematics is the foundation of logical reasoning. Mathematics is the foundation of logical reasoning. [*Hear! Hear!*] It is logical reasoning that dictates that when you add 1 to 1, you get 2. For this Meeting of Parliament, I have listened to my Friends on the other Side and anytime they add 1 to 1, they get 3. We do not get the logic of the arguments. It was yesterday when he confessed that he did not do Mathematics that I appreciated why I have not been getting the logic of the arguments.

Mr Speaker, I was not running away from debating him. I just realised that I should stop debating him. When he goes back to secondary school to do Mathematics and come back, we can then debate. [*Hear! Hear!*].

Mr Speaker, we have sufficient numbers to proceed with the Business for today and I think that we should proceed because these changes in the names must take place. They must take place. I know that we must be seen fighting it. But do not fight what you cannot fight successfully.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I always indicate that if your farm is not long, your water container need not be very big.

Hon Habib Iddrisu, let us hear you.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, thank you. The point might be made and I am happy that —

Mr Speaker, I always tell you that I respect you so much when it comes to the law. But sometimes when we allow the Majority Leader to mix up even though he is also a very good lawyer in standing. Sometimes he tries to mix up to get his numbers in.

Mr Speaker, the point must be made and it must be clear, that in the Constitution, there is a clear difference between Article 102 and 104 when it comes to Parliament. It is only Article 102 that is related to Standing Order 64. For that matter, I think that my application has not been fairly treated. You have unnecessarily delayed for the

Majority Leader to bring in numbers into the Chamber. Mr Speaker, I think that you have not been fair to me. I think that you have unnecessarily delayed for the Majority Leader to bring his numbers in here.

Mr Speaker, still think that for purposes of the *Hansard*, do the count. If we have 138. Then we can move on. But my application still stands under order 151(3).

Mr Speaker, I raised the issue in Article 104 of the Constitution and I read it. My application is properly made and I still advise you to look into my application. If we are 138, then we can move on.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib Iddrisu, you are still talking about Article 104. By what means do I determine that we have a decision-making quorum or not? It is by checking the numbers and what is the procedure for us to check the numbers?

3:40 p.m.

That is why Article 104 cannot be in isolation. We need to follow the procedure; they would ring the bell, I would call on the Clerk-at-the-Table to count the numbers for me, and if at the end of the counting, the numbers are not up to the Article 104 requirement, then we can make a decision. So, without following the procedure, I cannot just come and say that by Article 104, we do not have the numbers to take decision. Then, I would be delving into an arena of the Supreme Court, and I am telling you

that the Supreme Court has exclusive jurisdiction within the Constitution to interpret the Constitution.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am guided, but I am just surprised that it is Mr Ahiafor that I know in the 8th Parliament who was seated right here with the Constitution as his friend, not the Standing Orders. But, be as it may, I want to still draw your attention to Order 151(3), you have already put the Question, and Order 151(3) states: “A Member may challenge the decision of the Speaker on the voice vote and the Speaker shall determine whether to call for headcounts or electronic votes.”

So, Mr Speaker, that is my application.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is where the initial confusion was, because on one breath, you are calling Article 104, and on another breath, you are challenging the vote.

So, Hon Members, my decision on the voice vote has been challenged.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the rules do not say that when it is challenged, you must necessarily proceed to headcount. The rules state that: “A Member may challenge the decision of the Speaker on the voice vote and the Speaker shall determine whether to call for a headcount or electronic vote.”

Mr Speaker, the word is “shall determine.” Mr Speaker —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, what I want to do is, I will put the Question again —

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, that is the point I was going to make. That the Speaker shall make a determination, and the determination may extend to putting the Question again, and engaging the voice vote, and now take a decision.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is obvious the ayes have it [*Hear! Hear!*]

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I rise to invoke Order 151 of our rules.

Mr Speaker, in spite of your decision, by use of the phrase, “it is obvious that the ayes have it”. I arise to challenge that decision, and by challenging the decision, I draw your attention to Order 151(3), which states: “A Member may challenge the decision of the Speaker on the voice vote and the Speaker shall determine whether to call for a headcount or electronic vote.”

So, Mr Speaker, the mandatory provision is that when this is challenged, you have two options; to either call for a head count or go for an electronic vote.

So, Mr Speaker, that is the application before you. Thank you.

3:50 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, having regard to the challenge of my decision on the voice vote, I will proceed to call on all those who oppose the Motion to stand on their feet to be counted.

Hon Members, let me read the relevant Standing Order — “Procedure for headcount”:

“The Speaker shall take the votes of the House in the case of a headcount by calling upon Members who support or oppose the Question to rise in their places successively”.

So, Clerk to Parliament, we want you to count those who oppose the Motion.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, suffice to state that whilst you have chosen to count the ‘noes’ first, you are using that to give the ‘ayes’ the opportunity to continue to whip their Members in. That is exactly what you are doing. But Mr Speaker, we all know that when Hon Habib made this application, they were just 81. The Majority Leader used the opportunity to filibuster, to take pictures, and to whip people in.

Mr Speaker, that notwithstanding, we will keep by our principle, and stand. Even if we are two, we want *Hansard* to capture us.

Question put and the House was counted.

AYES	-	155
NOES	-	25
ABSTENTIONS	-	25

Resolved accordingly.

4:00 p.m.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I rise under Standing Order 152(6). With your permission, I read: “Where a Member rises to challenge the result of the headcount, the Speaker shall call for a Division.”

Mr Speaker, the number as reported to you by the Clerk, our Side we were not 25. Also, if you subject this to Division, I am very convinced that all the MPs on this Side from the Upper West Region, Upper East Region, Northern Region, and Savannah Region will vote. So, Mr Speaker, I invite you to Standing Order 152(6), I read: “Where a Member rises to challenge the result of the headcount, the Speaker shall call for a Division.”

Thank you.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I am sure, is aware of Order 154. Mr Speaker, Order 154: Division unnecessarily claimed. It states: “Despite Order 153...” Why does it say “Despite Order 153”? Because Order 152(6) says: “Where a Member rises to challenge the result of the headcount, the Speaker shall call for a Division.”

So, it will appear that it is mandatory for the Speaker to call for a division. But, if you go to Order 154, it says:

“Despite Order 153 the Speaker may, if in the opinion of the Speaker a division has been unnecessarily claimed, take the vote of the House, by calling upon the Members who support or who oppose the decision of the Speaker

to rise and be counted, upon which the Speaker shall declare the decision of the House or direct that a Division be held.”

What Order 154 is saying is that where the Speaker is of the opinion that the division is unnecessarily claimed, such as where the Side that is opposed to the decision, which Side is constituted by 87 Members, when they are counted and they are only 25 Members, and they still unnecessarily claim a Division, the Speaker may come to a conclusion that this is an unnecessarily claiming of Division. In which case, instead of calling for a Division, the Speaker can call for another count, and when there is another count, then the Speaker can make a declaration that his decision is right, or he will now call for a Division. So, there is no automatic right to call for a Division.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, you are right.

Osahen Afenyo- Markin: Mr Speaker, I think we must all pay attention to the rules. The Majority Leader, in opposing the application under 152(6), relies on Order 154. Order 154 is titled “Division unnecessarily claimed”. Now, the phrase starts with this:

“Despite Order 153, the speaker may, if in the opinion of the Speaker a division has been unnecessarily claimed, take the vote of the House...”

Mr Speaker, Order 154 anchors its strength on Order 153. The title for Order

153 is Procedure on Division. Mr Speaker, that is the second stage. We have not gone through any Division yet. So, for anybody to say the Majority Leader is right, I beg to submit that that is not the case. It would have been right if we had gone through Division, and Hon Habib is asking for Division again. That is where the rule —

4:10 p.m.

Hon Majority Leader finished his submission, nobody interrupted him. I need to finish. It is not you, Mr Speaker, it is them.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: If you had listened to what I wanted to say—I just want to admonish Members that we listen to each other in silence.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, Order 154 draws its oxygen from Order 153. We are not at Order 153. Hon Habib Iddrisu's first application was on Order 151. He has now moved to the second stage, which is Order 152. Now, after Order 152, you go into Division which is in Order 153. Now, Order 154 deals with a situation where a Division is being claimed unnecessarily. That is why it refers to Order 153, which in entirety deals with the procedure on Division. Order 153 states that:

“(1) The Speaker shall direct that the lobbies be cleared in the case of a Division, and the Division bells shall be rung for one minute.

- (2) The Speaker shall invite the Leadership of the Majority, Minority or Independent caucuses to appoint two Tellers each to observe the division process, after a lapse of five minutes.
- (3) The Speaker shall announce the names of Division Clerks and the Tellers.
- (4) The names of Members voting in a Division in the House shall be recorded by the Division Clerks before Members proceed through the *Ayes*, *Noes* and *Abstention* lobbies.
- (5) The Members shall be counted by the Tellers as they proceed through the *Ayes*, *Noes* and *Abstention* lobbies.
- (6) The Division Clerks shall submit the figures to the Clerk who shall write them on the appropriate form at the conclusion of voting.
- (7) If the Tellers disagree, the Clerk shall inform the Speaker of the disagreement who shall then direct that another Division be held.
- (8) The Clerk shall hand over the figures to the Speaker, who shall state the number of Members voting for the *AYES*, *NOES* or *ABSTENTIONS* and then declare the results of the Division.

- (9) Where a Member is incapacitated by some physical infirmity from passing through the lobbies, the Member shall, report the incapacity to the Speaker through the Clerk and upon verification, be counted and recorded.
- (10) If a Member states that he voted in error or that his vote was counted wrongly, the Member, may request that the vote be corrected or counted before the Speaker declares the result.
- (11) Where the numbers in a Division are equal, the Motion shall be considered lost.
- (12) Where a Deputy Speaker is presiding, the Deputy Speaker shall indicate a personal vote through the Clerk-at-the-Table, which vote shall be counted and recorded accordingly.”

So, Mr Speaker, the stage we are in, per his application, requires all the procedures under Order 153 to be followed.

Now, Order 154 that he relies on to object to his application is when the Member, after the Division, is still insisting that he is challenging the vote. It is at that point that, Mr Speaker, the rules require you to exercise a certain discretion as to whether to call for another headcount or proceed to do a Division. So, it is wrong to suggest that at this stage, we can rely on Order 154.

We cannot, because we have not gone into division at all for any argument to be made that a Division is unnecessarily claimed.

I so submit.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, when it comes to the interpretation of the Standing Orders, the rules are clear that it is the Speaker that interprets the Standing Orders. I do not base my interpretation on any parallel evidence but the rules.

Hon Members, let us look at the text of the Standing Orders. The Standing Orders is very clear, first on Voting by Members, that is Standing Order 151. Now, when the result of the vote is being challenged, then Order 152 kicks in, and Order 152 is consequent upon challenging the voice vote. Order 152 sets out the procedure, what we should do when the vote is challenged. Now, when you go through the procedure, and the results are declared, and the results of the headcount is being challenged, it is then that you come to a Division, and the procedure spelt out for the Division is in Standing Order 153. Now, Standing Order 154 states that “despite Standing Order 153”, that is despite the procedure for a Division,

“...the Speaker may, if in the opinion of the Speaker a Division has been unnecessarily claimed, take the vote of the House by calling upon the Members who support or who oppose the decision of the Speaker to rise and be counted, upon which the

Speaker shall declare the decision of the House or direct that a Division be held.”

Hon Members, by no stretch of interpretation can we say that it is after going through the Division exercise that the Speaker will determine that the Division is unnecessarily being claimed. That interpretation would amount to an absurdity.

Hon Members, in my opinion, the Division is therefore unnecessarily being claimed. On this note, I will call on those who oppose the Motion to stand on their feet to be counted. *[Pause]*

Hon Members, on this note, I take it that everybody is in favour of the Motion — *[Hear! Hear!]* — since I have not seen anybody on his feet to be counted. Hon Members, that is my ruling.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, since you are proceeding on the rules, the fact that you asked for the Noes vote and no one stood up does not mean that you will not call on the Ayes votes to also stand and be counted. If you decide to be one-Sided, Mr Speaker, you will be procedurally wrong.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Look at the rules before you jump into a conclusion that I am procedurally wrong. The phrase is that “the Speaker, by calling upon those Members who support, or”, so this is disjunctive, it is not conjunctive. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, this strange

interpretation of a so-called disjunctive phrase that you are introducing into this Chamber may come back one day to haunt each one of us. We have three forms of voting: Abstention, a Noe vote and an Aye vote.

Mr Speaker, if this Side decides to abstain, it does not mean that those who support, you will not call upon them to be counted. If you tell me that, you will either do one of the two—Mr Speaker, I am sorry.

4:20 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, you are entitled to your view, but in this particular case, when you are looking at Standing Order 154, what you are saying is totally and completely untenable.

Hon Members, can we make progress? Please. Minister for Education, you may now move Motion numbered 34.

MOTION

Suspension of Order 104(1)

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu) (MP): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 169(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that when a Bill has been read a second time, the Bill shall pass through a consideration stage which shall not be taken until at least two sitting days have elapsed, the

Consideration Stage of the C. K. Tedam University of Technology and Applied Sciences (Amendment) Bill, 2025 may be *taken* today.

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Peter Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE

C. K. Tedam University of Technology and Applied Sciences (Amendment) Bill, 2025

Clause 1 — Act 1000, amended.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, amendment proposed paragraph (a), line 2, after “Sciences”, insert “, Navrongo”.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Chairman sought to do an amendment, but he is supposed to tell us what the new rendition would be because the procedure is that whatever he is amending, he must give us the new rendition.

Let him give us the new rendition so it becomes clearer for us to follow.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the new rendition is, by the

substitution for the short title, “University of Technology and Applied Sciences, Navrongo Act 2019, Act 100”.

You may move amendment number two.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, I want to appeal that since the amendment is consequential throughout, you may instruct the drafters to do so.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Members, the amendment in the *Order Paper Addendum 2*, is consequential. So, I will put the question and direct the drafters to consequently amend. It is all inserting “Navrongo” after “Sciences” in the various provisions.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Clause 1 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 2 — Consequential Amendment.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, I beg to move paragraph (f), line 3, after “Sciences”, insert “, Navrongo”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is also consequential.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 2 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Long Title

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, I beg to move line 3, after “Sciences”, insert “Navrongo”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is also a consequential amendment.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

The Long Title as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this brings us to the end of the Consideration Stage of the C. K. Tadam, University of Technology and Applied Sciences (Amendment) Bill, 2025.

Hon Minister for Education, you may move the Motion numbered 36.

MOTION

Suspension of Order 172(1)

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 172(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that when a Bill has passed through the Consideration Stage, the third reading thereof shall not be taken until at least one sitting day has elapsed, the Motion for the Third Reading of the C. K. Tadam University of Technology and Applied Sciences (Amendment) Bill, 2025 may be *moved today*.

Chairman of the Committee (Mr Peter Kwasi Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

BILL — THIRD READING

C. K. Tadam University of Technology and Applied Sciences (Amendment) Bill, 2025

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That the C. K. Tadam University of Technology and Applied Sciences (Amendment) Bill, 2025 be now read the Third time.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, I beg second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

The C. K. Tadam University of Technology and Applied Sciences (Amendment) Bill, 2025—*read the Third time and passed.*

4:30 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, let us go to page 1 of the *Order Paper Addendum 2*. Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies (Amendment) Bill, 2025 at Consideration Stage.

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE

Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies (Amendment) Bill, 2025

Clause 1

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Peter Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, I beg to move paragraph (a), line 2, after “Studies”, insert “, Wa”.

I plead that since it runs through all the amendments in clause 1, all be taken at a go. Thank you.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 1 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will direct the draftsman to take note of those amendments.

Clause 2 — Consequential amendment.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, I beg to move: line 3, after “Studies”, insert “, Wa”.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 2 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Long Title — An ACT to amend the Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies Act, 2019, (Act 1001) to change

the name of the university to the University of Business and Integrated Development Studies and to provide for related matters.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, line 3, after “Studies”, insert “, Wa”.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Long Title ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, that brings us to the end of the Consideration Stage of Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies Bill, 2025.

Hon Minister for Education, you may now move the Motion numbered 30.

MOTION

Suspension of Order 172(1)

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 172(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that when a Bill has passed through the Consideration Stage, the third reading thereof shall not be taken until at least one sitting day has elapsed, the Motion for the Third Reading of the Simon Diedong

Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies (Amendment) Bill, 2025 may be moved today.

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Peter Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

BILL — THIRD READING

Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies (Amendment) Bill, 2025

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That the Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies (Amendment) Bill, 2025 be now read the Third time.

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Peter Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

The Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies (Amendment) Bill, 2025 — *read the Third time and passed.*

MOTION

Suspension of Order 104(1)

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 104(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that a Motion shall not be debated until at least two sitting days have elapsed after the notice to move the Motion is given, the Motion for the Second Reading of the Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025 may be moved today.

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Peter Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

BILL — SECOND READING

Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That the Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025 be now read a Second time.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Motion moved. I will call on the Chairperson of the Committee to present the Committee's Report.

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Peter Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, I beg to support the Motion and in doing so, present the Report of the Committee on Education on the Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025. I urge *Hansard* to capture the whole Report as having been read as I read the conclusion.

Introduction

The Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025 was laid before Parliament on Thursday, 18th December, 2025 by the Hon Minister for Education, Mr Haruna Iddrisu, in accordance with Article 106(1) of the Constitution of the Republic of Ghana, 1992 and Order 159(3) of the Standing Orders of Parliament. Pursuant to Article 106(4) of the 1992 Constitution and Order 250 of the Standing Orders of Parliament, the Speaker subsequently referred the Bill to the Committee on Education for consideration and report.

Deliberations

The Committee met with the Hon Minister for Education on Thursday, 18th December, 2025 to consider the Bill. The Committee expresses its profound gratitude to the Hon Minister for Education for attending upon the

Committee and providing clarification to issues raised at the meeting.

Reference Documents

The Committee referred to the following documents during the deliberations:

- i. The Constitution of the Republic of Ghana, 1992;
- ii. The Standing Orders of Parliament, 2024;
- iii. Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills and Entrepreneurial Development Act, 2020 (Act 1026);
- iv. Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025;
- v. The Education Regulatory Bodies Act, 2020 (Act 1023);
- vi. The Education Strategic Plan (ESP 2018-2030), 2018; and
- vii. The Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921).

Background

The Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development was established by an Act of Parliament (Act 1026) passed on 11th August 2020, with assent given on 27th August, 2020.

Purpose of The Bill

The Bill seeks to amend the Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development Act, 2020 (Act 1026) to change the name of the University to the University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development, Kumasi. The change of the name of the University also fosters stronger relationships between the University and relevant stakeholders to boost public interest, leading to higher enrolment, funding, and support from alumni and stakeholders. This renewed interest will further drive broader investment in higher education, benefiting both the educational and economic landscapes.

Many universities globally are changing names to reflect contemporary values and social justice. By following this trend, the University will enhance its global competitiveness and appeal to international students.

Summary of Provisions of the Bill

Clause 1 of the Bill amends the relevant provisions of Act 1026 to change the name of the University to the University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development. Clause 2 provides for the consequential amendment of relevant enactments. Under the clause, a reference in any other enactment to “Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development” is to be construed as a reference to “University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development”.

Observations

The observations below reflect the Committee’s review of the Bill, taking into account its deliberations and the inputs received from stakeholders.

Scope of the Proposed Amendments

The Committee observed that the Bill is primarily concerned with the renaming of the affected institution, largely involving the removal of personal or historically derived names and their replacement with functional or descriptive titles.

The Committee further noted that the proposed amendment does not introduce any substantive changes to the governance structure, statutory mandate, academic focus or operational framework of the university.

Rationale Advanced for the Renaming

The Committee noted that the Minister justified the proposed renaming on the grounds of international best practice and the promotion of national unity. In this regard, the Committee was informed that petitions had been received from traditional authorities and community leaders who perceived the existing names as exclusionary or divisive. Hon Members of the Committee questioned whether the proposed name of the university genuinely reflect international best practice. It was noted that many internationally recognised universities are geographically identifiable, including Oxford, Cambridge, and the University of Ghana. The Committee observed that

the adoption of generic institutional titles is largely consistent with established international practice.

Effective Financial Management for the Ensuing Year

The Committee took note that letter heads and other school properties are embossed with the name of the institution in accordance with standard corporate governance practices. Given that the year 2025 is ending, institutions would commence procedures for the commitment of funds towards, among others, securing branded stationery and other items for use during the ensuing year. To this end, committing funds to emboss school items only for the name of the institution to change within the first quarter of the year 2026, for which reason additional funds would be expended for rebranding, is not a prudent fiscal measure.

Accordingly, the Committee is convinced that it is crucial to consider the Bill as soon as practicable to enable the university commence the financial year with commitments towards the procurement of stationery and other items embossed with its new name.

Need for Geographic Identifiers in University Names

The Committee strongly agreed to incorporating geographic or location identifier – “Kumasi”, into the proposed university’s name. The Committee considered this necessary to enhance institutional clarity and identity, as well as to ensure consistency with existing

Acts that already specify the locations of main campuses.

Promoting National Identity and Inclusivity

The Committee was informed of persistent advocacy by stakeholders for the change of the name from Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development to the University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development, Kumasi. Accordingly, the Ministry of Education undertook stakeholder consultations prior to the proposed renaming of the University and drafting of the Bill. The Committee observed that the change in the name of the University is expected to foster stronger relationships between the institution and relevant stakeholders. This is anticipated to enhance public interest, leading to increased enrolment, improved funding opportunities, and stronger support from alumni and other stakeholders. The Committee noted that these outcomes would contribute to broader investment in higher education, with positive implications for both the educational and economic landscape. Accordingly, the views and inputs of relevant stakeholders were considered, thus ensuring inclusivity.

Proposed Amendments

The Committee proposed the attached amendments during its deliberations.

Conclusion

The Committee, having carefully examined the Akenten Appiah-Menka

University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025, is satisfied that the Bill is focused on the proposed renaming of the University and does not alter its statutory mandate, governance structures, or academic and operational framework. The Committee acknowledges the policy considerations advanced by the Minister for Education, including the objectives of national cohesion, stakeholder engagement, and global relevance.

The Committee, therefore, recommends that the House adopts this Report and pass the Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025 into law.

Question proposed.

Mr Mustapha Ussif (NPP — Yagaba Kubori): Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to comment on the Report of the Committee on Education on changing the name of the Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development to University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development. This university was established by the NPP Government in 2020, and the name Akenten Appiah-Menka was given to the university for a purpose. The said name is the name of a prominent entrepreneur in the Ashanti Region and in Ghana. In Ghana, the name resonates with all businesses, businessmen and women in this country.

4:40 p.m.

The purpose for giving that name to that University, especially to train the young men and women in business training, skills and entrepreneurship was to inspire them so that they can look up to him and develop enterprises and industries. For a new Government that has come to reset, the expectation was that they would establish a new university, not to change the name. Be as it may, we have no option than to support them, and that is my comment to it.

Mr Speaker, thank you so much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Fred Kyei Asamoah?

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah (NPP — Offinso North): Mr Speaker, thank you, I quite remember in 2020 when Parliament was passing the Bill to establish the Akenten Appiah–Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development. I had the opportunity to work with the Committee on Education. Mr Speaker, an extensive engagement with all the stakeholders, including the Otumfuo Osei Tutu II, were all engaged, and I remember the first occasion he was also present.

Akenten Appiah–Menka is a Ghanaian who was once a Deputy Minister for Trade for this country. He was also once a Deputy Attorney-General of this country. Appiah–Menka's name resonates across all businesses in this country and for the object for which this University is being established, to make sure it has a good

linkage with industry, with businesses, so our teeming youth do not come after school looking for public-service jobs. Rather, they will be looking at private-sector jobs, and to be innovative and create jobs and employ other people. It is quite unfortunate, and I repeat that it is a sad day that we are killing the spirit of young Ghanaians who intend to emulate such people like Akenten Appiah-Menka who has led a life that young men and women of this country can look up to and also develop so much and be independent enough to establish their own jobs and employ people.

Mr Speaker, today, just after 2020, when this University was established, the NPP Government under Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo has contributed so much and has supported the University with huge amount of equipment, spanning from civil engineering, electrical engineering, mechanical engineering and the rest. This is what we are expecting the Minister for Education and the Government to come to this honourable House to ask for support, because this is about skills training and entrepreneurial mindset. We want Ghanaians to start thinking outside the box and the culture of change to make sure that our young ones will not come out of university and be looking for government jobs or public-sector jobs, but they can create their own jobs in collaboration with the private sector.

Mr Speaker, today, I am even told that this man, Akenten Appiah-Menka contributed to the drafting of the Constitution of this country. Today, we are killing that spirit. We are pleading

with the Hon Minister to look at it again and withdraw this Bill, because Ghanaians are being told it is no longer a good thing to be an entrepreneur or to serve your nation — like the earlier argument the Minister was making.

Mr Speaker, every university that we can think of —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, from the Reports and the Memorandum accompanying the Bill, where are Ghanaians being told what you are saying?

Dr Kyei Asamoah: Mr Speaker, every Bill and every Act has a spirit behind it, and I am referring to the spirit behind this Bill. That is what I know, Mr Speaker, at the time of consideration of this Bill, you were part of the Committee on Education and you had the opportunity to contribute.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What does Order 127 say? Did Order 127 say you speak on the spirit. The spirit may be your own imagination, but the law says you debate on the basis of explanatory memorandum and the Report of the Committee.

Dr Kyei Asamoah: Mr Speaker, I know I am not a lawyer, but any time a law needs to be interpreted, each judge interprets it based on their own appreciation of the law. That is why one judge can make a ruling and another judge can overturn that ruling.

Mr Speaker, notwithstanding —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is why the law is trying to tell us what we should do. But I do not want a situation where they will say that you are misleading, which will become a matter of privileges. That is why I am drawing your attention to the fact that you are saying we are being told by the Bill. It is as if that indication is in the Bill.

Dr Kyei Asamoah: Mr Speaker, we are looking at the principle here. It is the principle that we are looking at. If we look at the Report of the Committee, it says;

“The Akenten Appiah–Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development was established by an Act of Parliament, Act 1026 passed on 11th August, 2020 with an assent given on the 27th of August, 2020.”

So, this is a new University, it is barely 10 years old.

Mr Speaker, this University that is supposed to support skills training is barely 10 years old and we are not doing anything to add up to the University, but we are changing the name. No other person like a strong Ashanti who has been an entrepreneur, an academician, a politician and a lawyer. These are people we want others to look up to and ask why he was named after a university.

Mr Speaker, today we are killing the spirit of a lot of Ashanti young men who aspire to grow, be academicians and be businessmen as well. That is all we are saying. It is the principle. So, what we

are asking is that the Hon Minister and His Excellency the President to re-look at this Bill again. Because this Bill had an engagement and I believe the people of Ashanti, the young men—Are we are saying that Akenten Appiah–Menka does not deserve to have a university named after him in the Ashanti region? The same principle was being argued here by the Majority Leader, that were there no good people in the Northern Region to be named after. So, are we telling Ashantis that Akenten Appiah–Menka is not a good example for Ashantis? Growing up, there was Appiah-Menka soap and almost everybody within the Chamber knows about Appiah–Menka soap.

Mr Speaker, we are asking the Minister for Education to please reconsider withdrawing this Bill and keeping the name Akenten Appiah–Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development. If he should come back to this Chamber, to come and ask that we contribute or we provide extra equipment for this University. We give them enough resources to embark on strong research so that they can work in this industry.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I would like to state emphatically that I will oppose the Bill and this Report. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Leadership?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I would yield to Hon Vincent Ekow Assafuah.

Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah (NPP — Old Tafo): Mr Speaker, a country that fails to honour its heroes is not worth dying for. We are setting a very bad precedent. The precedent that we are setting today is that irrespective of one's talent, irrespective of one's sacrifices, it is meaningless to sacrifice for this country.

Mr Speaker, in 1960, when Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology was a University of Science and Technology, it was on a certain basis or rationale for us to now change the name from University of Science and Technology and name it after one of our heroes, who is Kwame Nkrumah in the Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology.

4:50 p.m.

Mr Speaker, how do we decide to turn the clock backwards, when we have decided that we will name a university after somebody who has sacrificed enormously for this country? *[Interruption]* Mr Speaker, it is a dangerous precedent and we should not allow it to fester. It is a dangerous precedent and we should not allow it to continue.

Mr Speaker, apart from that, has the Committee on Education and the Minister considered the financial and administrative costs to the state? Today, if you go to the Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development, everything that is in the university now would have to be changed to a new name. Have they

considered the cost to the state? It is a dangerous precedent and I am worried as a Member of Parliament in that region, and we are looking on for people to go ahead with this kind of mess. We cannot allow it to fester.

Mr Speaker, there is also a historical evolution that we need to protect. When I was on the Committee on Education, I remember at the time, there was a briefing from the Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology, who made us understand the rationale behind the establishment of the University. In fact, the Minister for Education, last three to four days when we met at the Committee, indicated the reason the Otumfuo Nana Osei Tutu II is made a Chancellor on the Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology's Council. The reason is that, his predecessor played a crucial role in the establishment of the University. The same philosophy should be applied here. The same philosophy is that, people who have played a role and contributed to the establishment of the University, cannot be overlooked, especially when we are giving certain nomenclatures to it.

Mr Speaker, it is a bad precedent and we should not allow it to fester. We should not allow it to happen. We on this Side are opposing the name change of Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development, to the University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development, it is a very bad precedent.

Thank you very much for the opportunity.

Question put Motion agreed to.

Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025 be now read a *Second* time.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I pray you that we take the Motion numbered 40.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Motion numbered 42. The Minister for Education.

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, with your indulgence, it is the Motion numbered 40 on page 17.

MOTION

Suspension of Order 169(1)

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 169(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that when a bill has been read a second time, the Bill shall pass through a consideration stage which shall not be taken until at least two sitting days have elapsed, the Consideration Stage of the Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025 may be *taken* today.

Chairperson of Committee (Mr Peter Kwasi Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Question put Motion agreed to.

Resolved Accordingly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Let us take the Motion numbered 41.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The item numbered 41 is for the Consideration Stage in the main *Order Paper*. Can you check it? So, we move the Motion numbered 43. So, the Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025 at Consideration Stage.

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE

Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025

Clause 1 — Act 1026 amended

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Peter Kwasi Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*, paragraph (a), line 2, after “Development”, *insert*, Kumasi.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 1 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 2 — Consequential amendment.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, line 3, after “Development”, insert “Kumasi”.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 2 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Long Title —

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, I beg to move: line 3, after “Development”, insert “Kumasi”.

Question put Amendment agreed to.

The Long Title as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this brings us to the Consideration Stage of Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025.

Hon Minister, you may now move the Motion numbered 42.

MOTION

Suspension of Order 172(1)

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I beg to move;

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 172(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that when a Bill has passed through the

Consideration Stage, the third reading thereof shall not be taken until at least one sitting day has elapsed, the Motion for the Third Reading of the Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025 may be moved today.

Chairperson of Committee (Mr Peter Kwasi Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Question put Motion agreed to.

Resolved Accordingly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Now, we move to the Motion numbered 43.

BILL — THIRD READING

Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That the Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025 be now read the third time.

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Peter Kwasi Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Question put Motion agreed to.

Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development (Amendment) Bill, 2025 — *read the Third time and passed.*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the indications are that we take a short suspension for about an hour. So that we can come back and deal with the outstanding issues.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, can we make it 30 minutes?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I plead that we do it one hour to be able to resolve all outstanding matters.

5:00 p.m.

So, that when we come back, you can, with alacrity, go through the ceremonial Motions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I thought we would be doing the Closed Sitting.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, 30 minutes is agreed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the House is temporarily suspended for 30 minutes.

5:01 — *Sitting suspended.*

7:05 p.m. — *Sitting resumed.*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, welcome back. It is now time

to take the closing remarks from the Leaders. The Speaker will also give his remarks, then we will adjourn the House. On this note, I will call on the Minority Leadership to give their closing remarks.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the Minority Leader is on his way. He should be here in a few minutes. We are not waiting. He is almost here.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, do I suspend the House and come back?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, if it is your pleasure. When we met at Conclave, I signalled him, then he left the office. So, he should be here in a jiffy. *[Interruption]* I am not saying we should wait for him. I am telling the Speaker the state of affairs.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is not good for the optics.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I know the Majority has some important Business. But there are Statements. We can do Questions. Mr Speaker, we can do Questions. He should be here in a few minutes.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Majority Leader, any indication?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, maybe we can take a three-minute suspension, because it will take about—He just left the office. Five minutes' suspension.

7:10 p.m. — *Sitting suspended.*

7:15 p.m. — *Sitting resumed.*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, without wasting my time, I will give the opportunity to the Minority Leader to make his concluding remarks.

CLOSING REMARKS

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, let me first apologise to you for my inability to be here earlier when you sat in the Chair. Some other engagement delayed me from my office to the Chamber. I thank you for indulging me.

Mr Speaker, Colleagues in Leadership, dear Colleagues, this Chamber has echoed with many closings. Today, as we have gathered, I know that we do not gather merely to conclude a Meeting or Session, but on our part as Minority, we are closing to confront the truth. In our view, our country is in danger, our democracy is under attack from within, our young people are dying in preventable tragedies, their futures are being destroyed in failing schools, and millions of them have no work and no hope. Our laws are being twisted, our institutions are being weakened, and our voice is being ignored. To stay quiet now would be a betrayal of the people we serve. It would be a betrayal of Ghana.

So today, we, the Minority take a stand. We draw a line. We choose to speak again and again. History has a way of testing nations. It tests them not in moments of triumph, but in moments of temptation. It tests them not when the path is clear, but when the fog is thick, and it judges them not by their ways, but by their choices. Ghana stands at such a

crossroad today. Our people are tired; tired of watching their 1992 Constitution treated as a suggestion; tired of seeing a human life reduced to numbers in press conference; tired of a Parliament that sometimes forgets it speaks for the people, not for the executive. From this Side of the aisle, we say enough is enough.

Mr Speaker, before I speak of policies and politics, let me speak of people; real people, young people. Ghanaians who will never come home. Last month, six women woke up early to be part of the many who were going to participate in the recruitment exercise at El-Wak Stadium. They went with dreams of serving in Ghana's Armed Forces. They went with hope in their hearts. By the end of that day, they lost their lives. A recruitment exercise, something that should have been a routine, became a death trap. Thousands surged through gates; the crash was inevitable. The tragedy was preventable.

Mr Speaker, I have seen the faces of these six young people. I have read their names. I think of their mothers who prepared breakfast that morning, not knowing it would be the last meal they would ever cook for their children. I think of their fathers who waved goodbye and expected them home by evening. What did those families get? A Board of Enquiry? Statements of regret; promises to investigate. But what they did not get was their children back, and still, not a single official has been held accountable. Not one person has resigned. Not one career has ended because six young Ghanaians died needlessly on their watch.

Mr Speaker, earlier this year, eight more Ghanaians boarded a military helicopter. They were on national assignments, serving their country. The helicopter crashed in Obuasi, and all eight died, including top Ministers of State. The investigation ruled it an accident. Questions remain unanswered. Again, no accountability. Again, families are left to grieve while officials move on.

And, Mr Speaker, from the death of the young, let me turn to the destruction of their dreams. We, in the Minority, when our party was in office, handed over an education system that was in the best shape it had ever been, although it was not perfect. West African Senior School Certificate Examination (WASSCE) results were improving year after year. Our Free SHS policy by Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo has opened doors for millions. Our investment in infrastructure, teacher training, and curriculum reforms was bearing fruit. We were building a future. But what has happened in less than a year?

The 2025 WASSCE results tell a story that should shame every one of us in this Chamber, especially those of our Friends in Government. Two hundred and twenty thousand candidates failed core Mathematics. Let that number sink in. More than half of all students who sat for the exam had the worst performance in seven years. F9 rates have exploded, pass rates have collapsed, and the failure rate has quadrupled compared to last year.

Mr Speaker, these are not just numbers on spreadsheets. These are

children who studied late into the night. These are parents who sacrificed to pay for extra classes. These are teachers who did their best with fewer resources and less support. These are 220,000 doors slammed shut. Universities deferred, career paths blocked, and future dimmed. The so-called apostles of reset promised transformation. What they have delivered is devastation. We left them an education system that was rising. They have driven it into the ground. When our children fail, Ghana fails. When we destroy the ladder that lifts the next generation, we destroy the nation's tomorrow.

This Government promised a 24-Hour Economy; one job, three shifts. Where is it? That promise has been a massive failure, a disappointment, a slap in the face of the youth? Mr Speaker, Ghana cannot afford to keep its youth idle. The saying is old but true. The devil finds work for idle hands. Is it any wonder that youth-related violent crimes are increasingly in the press? Is it any wonder that in some communities, young people are abandoning classrooms to chase illegal mining? Is it any wonder that betting shops are now filled with other youth gambling away their future? When 1.3 million young people have nothing to do, when youth unemployment reaches 32.5 per cent, when graduates cannot find work, and school leavers see no future, that is a national security threat.

Mr Speaker, a political party does not exist merely to win power and reward its big men with ministerial posts. A party does not exist to enrich cronies and

appoint party loyalists to comfortable positions. A party exists to govern, and the test of governing is not how many jobs you create for your friends. It is how many jobs you create for the people. The real measure of a government's thinking capacity is whether it can roll out policies that unleash the energies of the youth. Policies that turn frustration into productivity. Policies that give hope instead of despair. This Government has failed that test. It has presided over collapsed education. It has watched youth unemployment soar. It has offered no credible plans for job creation. It has expanded budgetary allocation to the Presidency for payment of salaries, while the real sectors of the economy get paltry amounts.

7:25 p.m.

This Government must wake up. It must understand that its first duty is not to its party apparatus. Its first duty is to the young people of this country, and if it cannot create jobs, if it cannot offer hope, if it cannot give our youth a future, then the question that begs for an answer is why did it seek the mandate of the good people of Ghana with lofty promises?

Mr Speaker, let me now turn to the attacks on our democracy itself, manipulation of parliamentary representation. We have seen clear manipulation of parliamentary representation through our courts. And I dare say, on behalf of the Minority, that democracy rests on one sacred principle, the people choose their representatives, not judges, not bureaucrats, not political

schemers working in the shadows. Yet we have watched a calculated assault on parliamentary representation unfold before our eyes. In Kpandai, a single high court judge sought to annul an election and order a rerun. This House rushed to declare the seat vacant. We urged restraint. We pleaded for patience. We asked that a higher court be heard. We were ignored. It took the Supreme Court on 16th December, 2025, to remind this Nation that constitutional questions are not administrative footnotes. The Court ordered the Electoral Commission to halt all preparations, not because the law was unclear, but because the haste was dangerous.

In Suhum, another attempt was stopped by the high court before it could succeed. But across this country, similar schemes are being hatched and we, the Minority, are aware. Let the record show, this Minority will fight to protect every mandate the people gave our Colleagues. We have seen this playbook in other democracies, where courtrooms become backdoors for reshaping parliament. We will not let that happen here. The Constitution demands respect for the will of the people, not convenience, not shortcuts, not political games dressed in legal language.

Mr Speaker, lurking behind these attacks on representation is something even darker; whispers, quiet conversations, plans being drawn in certain circles for a third-term presidential term. Some speak of creative constitutional interpretation. Others hint at amendments. All of them have forgotten one simple truth; sovereignty

belongs to the people, not those who sit in power. And let us be clear, as a midday sun, such schemes will not pass, not on this Minority's watch, not while Ghanaians are awake and vigilant. We, the Minority, will use every tool the Constitution gives us: debates, Motions, court actions, public mobilisation, to stop any attempt to extend this government's mandate beyond what the law permits.

Mr Speaker, we remain deeply troubled by the repeated introduction of government Business under certificate of urgency without prior notification, adequate consultation and sufficient time for proper scrutiny. While the Constitution permits emergency procedures under specific circumstances, such provisions are intended to be exceptional. We have witnessed instances where Bills of significant national interest were laid before the House under certificate of urgency with little opportunity for Members to peruse their implications, consult relevant stakeholders or subject them to rigorous debate. This approach undermines the very essence of legislation. A recent example is the Lithium Agreement, which had to be withdrawn. The Minority sounded alarmed but it was ignored. Eventually, when civil society echoed our views on this floor, Government took a U-turn and came to eat a humble pie, leading to the withdrawal of the Agreement. We, the Minority, consider this as a major policy failure because the Agreement had gone to Cabinet; Cabinet had approved, and they brought it here. And when we raised the issue, government officials insisted that it was a right Agreement. We hereby

re-echo our position earlier this week that the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, Hon Armah-Kofi Buah, must resign over this unfortunate situation.

Mr Speaker, this Government has also tried to destroy the very institutions meant to hold it accountable. When the Office of the Special Prosecutor began investigating people close to the ruling party, what did we see? We saw a Private Member's Bill showing its head under the Majority Leader and the Majority Chief Whip. What they sought to do was to abolish that Office. This move came as a shock to all who genuinely care about accountability. It is particularly jarring because it directly contradicted the President's own stated support for the OSP when he said, "a vital cock in the fight against corruption". The Minority Caucus, immediately upon learning of this Bill, publicly condemned the attempt to dismantle the OSP. We found it unacceptable that while the President was praising the Special Prosecutor, his Leaders in Parliament were moving to scrap that very Office. Thanks to the public outcry, the President intervened and the Bill was withdrawn at its instance. However, the damage was already done. This episode dealt a blow to the credibility of Government's anti-corruption posture.

Beyond the OSP incident, the anti-corruption effort so far appears one-sided. We observed that when this Government took office, all party members who were facing prosecution were freed through *nolle prosequi*. We observed that the vast majority of corruption investigations that have been

launched have targeted officials of previous administrations, including Members of Parliament on the Minority Caucus. Mr Speaker, it is sad to say that any time the state agencies hear former appointees who are Members of this Side speak on national issues, they invite them with threats, and this is unacceptable. The attempt is to cower them not to speak. We ask, why this bad faith investigation? Is it to shut us, to silence us? And when they hear any appointee who is a Member of Parliament on the Minority Side speaks, the next thing is threats. Sometimes, in this very Chamber, there are open threats and name-calling. This must stop.

Mr Speaker, beyond the OSP, the anti-corruption effort so far appears one-sided, as I have said, and we have seen it in action. The Minority has no objection whatsoever to any wrongdoing being investigated. Our position is that the fight against corruption must be genuine and non-partisan. It must not be used to blackmail us. Merely serving your nation in that capacity as a government appointee should not mean that if you are in opposition today, you must not speak.

Mr Speaker, democracy relies heavily on respect for the rule of law. State institutions must act impartially and protect the rights of all citizens. During this Session, the Minority has become concerned about signs of political intimidation and weakening due process. Action by some state agencies suggests targeting opposition figures, which threatens democratic stability. Our Bono Regional Chairperson, Abronye, was targeted, and we know that

our Ashanti Regional Chairperson is undergoing what we call malicious prosecution. We have also seen instances where the right to bail and fair treatment have been ignored. Some opposition figures have been held in custody, contrary to Article 14 of the Constitution. This trend is troubling. We want to encourage the Economic and Organised Crime Office (EOCO) to undertake its work with professionalism.

7:35 p.m.

The way they are using bail to intimidate, frustrate, and deny some known NPP officials of their rights is most unfair. This must stop. The law must protect every citizen equally, and any departure from these safeguards creates a serious risk for our democracy. Mr Speaker, when a Government's first response to an investigation is to take up the investigator, democracy is in danger. *[Pause]*

Mr Speaker, this House was rushed into a process to install a new Chief Justice even as matters touching that very vacancy were still before our court and the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) Court. The separation of powers is not a suggestion nor an option; it is the foundation on which our democracy stands. When the political branches behave as though pending court cases are mere formalities to be brushed aside, they shake that foundation.

Mr Speaker, while the Government destroys our institutions, it has also crushed ordinary Ghanaians under

economic hardship. Within a year, we have seen electricity tariffs going up to 27 per cent. Organised labour has signalled that this is unacceptable, and the alarm bells have rung. Families are suffering. Food prices remain high. Transport costs eat into wages. Fuel prices climb while incomes stand still. Parents struggle to pay fees. Small businesses close their doors. Households cut back on meals. And what does this Government do? It indulges in wasteful spending. It launches questionable projects while preaching austerity to everyone else. They are buying a presidential jet, which they themselves criticised.

Today, those they have recruited at the Presidency have ballooned, and they are spending so much to pay them. They have abandoned agriculture, and we have not seen production increase. Today, the private sector is suffering. They took away the policy of the One District One Factory (1D1F), which offers no incentive to the private sector. Mr Speaker, the social contract is breaking when those at the top live in comfort, while those at the bottom are told to tighten their belts. At the same time, our mineral wealth is being sold off in shady deals. The lithium agreement, we repeat, is opaque. The terms favour foreign and local investors, while communities get nothing. The details are hidden. The Draft Mining Royalty Regulations are being rushed through as subsidiary legislation, without transparency or proper scrutiny, creating loopholes for the well-connected.

Mr Speaker, the Chamber of Mines has sounded an alarm. We urge the

Government to withdraw this regulation and engage in broader stakeholder consultation. Our gold, our lithium, our future, being redesigned through the back door while Ghanaians are kept in the dark, is most unfortunate and unacceptable.

Mr Speaker, let me turn my attention to foreign policy. It is our view that this Government has also tarnished Ghana's hard-won reputation on the world stage. Ghana was once a respected voice on the global stage, and Nkrumah showed us how. We were principled and strategic. Today, that careful statecraft has been replaced by impulsiveness. We see what we call a rather reckless situation, instead of steady leadership. Look at the recent clash with the United States. It was over commercial debts. It ended with a defiant statement: "We owe you nothing". That line may have pleased some at home, but it was, in our view, reckless. It turned a complex financial issue into a public fight. That dispute required quiet, technical talks, not shouting.

We saw the same pattern with Israel. There was an unfortunate issue in Israel involving our citizens. Instead of calm fact-finding and private diplomacy, we chose a loud public confrontation. We used a microphone when we needed a quiet conversation between partners. In both cases, small problems were blown up into political drama. This shows a dangerous shift. Under this Government, foreign policy is now a state for domestic politics. It is no longer a careful tool to protect Ghana's long-term interests.

Let me be clear, we fully support a foreign policy that has set Ghana's

interests, and we fully support a decision to protect our citizens, and we fully support a decision to lawfully protect every Ghanaian everywhere. But what our Ministry of Foreign Affairs must remember is that a foreign policy is about interests, power, and values. When cool heads are required, there is no place for “buga buga” in the diplomatic arena. We have lost our measured wits and steady nerves. It is time to find them again. This is not smart diplomacy. This Government must end this approach.

Mr Speaker, we also see a one-sided House. That line is clear and bright. There will be no third term by any stilt. There will be no quiet destruction of independent institutions. There will be no constitutional violations dressed as legal creativity. We will use every tool the 1992 Constitution gives a vigilant Minority: We will debate. We will file Motions. We will go to court. We will mobilise public opinion. We will not stand by while this Government dismantles what generations built.

Mr Speaker, our people are wary, but they are not defeated. They wait, not from partisan hatred, but from a hunger for competence, decency, and for a government that respects the Constitution and values lives. When change comes, history recalls two groups of people: one chose silence, one chose convenience, and one looked away. The other stood its ground, defended the constitution, and spoke for the people. We, the mighty Minority, are the second group. We are the latter. [*Hear! Hear!*]

We stood our ground, defended this Constitution, and spoke for the people.

Mr Speaker, it is the practise of democracy that strengthens democracy. Democracy does not become strong simply because it exists on paper. It becomes strong because it is exercised properly and consistently. Put simply, writing or amending a constitution does not make a country democratic. Holding elections alone does not make a country democratic. Calling a system democratic does not make it so. What strengthens democracy is the daily practice of it—respecting the rule of law, even when it restrains those in power and allowing Parliament to function independently. Protecting minority voices, dissent and opposition. Following due process, not shortcuts. Accepting accountability and scrutiny, and obeying and adhering to constitutional limits.

Ghana stands at a critical democratic moment today, not because our democracy has failed us, but because its spirit is being tested. The question before us is not whether democracy is still suitable for us, but whether those entrusted with power are willing to submit themselves to its discipline. No authoritarian system ever admits that it is authoritarian. Tyranny often disguises itself as democracy until it is too late.

7:45 p.m.

This movement, therefore, calls not only on political actors, but on all pillars of our democracy. We are all involved in building our motherland and sustaining its democracy. We need a media that is

courageous, free and fair. We need faith institutions that model integrity and elevate national unity. We need civil society to remain a sanctuary of truth, free enquiry and intellectual honesty. We need citizens who are active participants in our democracy, not passive spectators to its erosion. The cause of freedom and justice is a defining responsibility of our cause. Though defending it is demanding, we the Caucus shall not relent. We the Minority will not sit by and fold our arm until it is too late. The spirit of the mighty Minority Caucus does not say we will manage democratic decline under this Government. It does not say we will adapt to injustice. It says we will resist oppression and we will overcome. Overcome we shall, through courage, through principle, through unity, and through unwavering commitment to the democratic values that bind us as one people.

Mr Speaker, in 1963, Martin Luther King stood before thousands and said,

“We cannot walk alone and as we walk we must make the pledge that we shall always march ahead. We cannot turn back.” [*I Have a Dream* by Martin Luther King]

By this, we the mighty Minority say to the Majority that we will march with the people. We march with the 1992 Constitution. We march with those whose voices have been silenced. We march with the 1.3 million young people who deserve better than this Government has given them, and we will not turn back. As we close this Meeting, let us close with resolve. A warning to those

who test the people's patience. The people are watching, the 1992 Constitution is waiting, and the youth are restless. For all who believe that in Ghana it is the 1992 Constitution, not the whims of those in power, that shall have that last word.

Mr Speaker, as we bring this Meeting and Session to a close, let me express gratitude to Colleagues in Leadership on both Sides of the House, especially our Whips. They work tirelessly to get Members into the Chamber. What will life be without our Whips? To our Backbench, the new ones who are learning the rules, we have seen promise in you. We have seen your talent at display. Keep to it. Do not give up. I say to those of you who have already warmed up. For those of you who are warming up, please, your days are ahead. Do not give up. Whether we have agreed or disagreed, debated or collaborated, I say to you, thank you for your service to the people of Ghana. This Chamber works because we show up, we speak up, and we hold each other accountable.

Mr Speaker, to the staff of Parliament, the Clerks, the security personnel, the administrators, the clerks behind the scenes, we say, thank you. Your professionalism keeps this House functioning. Your dedication often goes unnoticed, but it does not go unappreciated. To the Clerk to Parliament himself, Mr Ebenezer Ahumah Djietror, you have taken all the bullets from our Side and from the other Side. It is alright to say you have held this Chamber together. God bless you and your team for your effort.

To the members of the press, the reporters, the cameramen, and the editors, thank you for keeping the public informed. A free press is the lifeblood of democracy. Your work ensures that what happens in this Chamber reaches every corner of Ghana and beyond.

Last but not the least, to the Rt Hon Speaker and his two deputies. From our hearts, we say thank you. We have seen the transformation in Parliament. We may disagree on many issues, but what we know is that you are providing leadership for this House. We will continue to use every legitimate means to challenge your ruling, and in doing so, we mean no disrespect. It is democracy in action.

Mr Speaker, to the two deputies, particularly the First Deputy Speaker. Mr First Deputy Speaker, we know this is your first time of being a First Deputy Speaker. We have often given you hard times, but bear with us. This is democracy in action. Be patient. Be tolerant. Accommodate us. Have a big belly to contain us. We know sometimes we test your patience, but again, I say to you, democracy in action.

To the Second Deputy Speaker, there are times, although we are of the same stock, we have disagreed. But again, I say to you, we have tested your patience. We have tested your tenacity. We have tested your resilience. But again, we are your own. Do not give up on us. Democracy in action.

Some Hon Members: Speaker oo Speaker!

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, to the good people of Ghana, we, the Minority, say to you, thank you for your patience, your vigilance, and your faith in this democratic experiment we call the Fourth Republic. As we prepare to adjourn, the season of Christmas is upon us. To all Hon Members, please spend time with the family. We have worked hard enough. Let us use the period to check our health. When we leave this ordinary abode, the 1992 Constitution requires that there must be a replacement. Life will go on without you. Please spend time to check on your health. Do not be so scared to know your medical condition. It is better to know to treat it than to live in that fear of not knowing, then it will get worse. Please check on your health.

Mr Speaker, while I wish my Colleagues a Merry Christmas, let me say that let the season bring you peace in your very homes, joy to your hearts, and hope for the year ahead. May we return in the new year with renewed energy, clearer purpose, and deeper commitment to serving the people who sent us here, and hoping that the Hon First Deputy Speaker will resist the temptation of hauling the Minority Leader before a so-called Privileges Committee. The Minority Leader will insist on his rights on serving his full term as a Third Deputy Speaker at ECOWAS Parliament. Therefore, it is our prayer that the First Deputy Speaker and his Committee will resist all temptations of being pushed to do that which is never done in any democracy. The Minority Leader has not disrespected any Order of this House. Indeed, the ECOWAS

Parliament rejected, outrightly, the Resolution that sought to remove the Minority Leader from his seat as an ECOWAS Member Parliament. The Minority Leader's seat at ECOWAS Parliament is not one of those that can be removed. You can remove the Chief Justice. You can remove others who are political appointees. But not his *bona fide* rights as a member of ECOWAS Parliament and a Third Deputy Speaker. He shall remain until April 2028, when his tenure shall come to an end.

Mr Speaker, thank you so much indeed. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is now the turn of the Majority Leader to give his closing remarks.

7:55 p.m.

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, I am most grateful for the opportunity to deliver my closing remarks as the House adjourns *sine die* for the Christmas Holidays and its associated festivities.

Mr Speaker, as representatives of the people, it is time for us to return to our constituents and the good people of this country as Christmas approaches, as the New Year festivities begin, and as the year ends.

Mr Speaker, first and foremost, I would like to commend all of us. Let me join the Hon Minority Leader to commend all those who have helped us to have a successful Meeting of the

House. Before I delve into the details of my closing remarks, let me just briefly address some issues that the Hon Minority Leader has raised.

Mr Speaker, our Standing Orders and our Constitution have made provision for this House to be able to act expeditiously when it so desires, and that is why we have provisions that allow us to bring Business under a certificate of urgency. I believe that the certificate of urgency is an instrument that is available to us. It enables us to act with dispatch as a House. I do not believe that the tool of certificate of urgency has been abused by anybody in this House, and this is not the first time that we have utilised the tool of certificate of urgency to pass legislation. The use of a certificate of urgency is not meant to guard or prevent the Minority from participating in criticising or critiquing and pointing out difficulties or problems with any policy proposal. Even when we bring anything under certificate of urgency, we still create room for people who have issues to raise those issues. So, sometimes when it is presented to the public as if any time that we are passing anything through a certificate of urgency, then there is something that is being hidden, that is not really fair, and also misrepresents how this House functions.

Mr Speaker, I am not aware that there is any attempt to gag the Minority by the use of investigative agencies. I have been in this House for close to two decades. I have been in this House as a Member of the opposition; I have been in this House as a Minister; I have been in this House back again as an opposition

Member; and I have been in this House now, serving as the Hon Majority Leader; in and out of power and in and out of the Chamber.

Mr Speaker, I can assure you that those of us who are in this House, who get to serve as Hon Ministers, who get to serve on Boards, as Board Chairpersons, or as Board Members, which is an Executive department, we should watch our activities carefully as Ministers and as Board Members because there is always a day when we will be called upon to come and answer for our conduct either as Ministers, as Board Members or as Board Chairpersons.

Mr Speaker, when we leave office in the Executive capacity, and we remain in this House, and the law enforcement agencies are calling upon us to come and account, we should not treat that as an attempt to gag anybody because when we were accepting those appointments, nobody forced us to accept those appointments. It is only fair that when one accepts to serve in an Executive position, when the day of recording arrives, one should be ready to go and answer for their deeds or misdeeds. If there are misdeeds, one would be held accountable; if there are good deeds, one would be able to exonerate oneself in court.

Mr Speaker, not too long ago, the Hon Minority Leader in this House, when we were in opposition, and that is Dr Cassiel Ato Forson, who is now the Hon Minister for Finance and Acting as Minister for Defence, I was in this Chamber when every morning he had to

go to court, answer in court and then come here to lead the Minority; he never complained one single day. He answered, defended himself, and finally got exonerated, and the matter was disposed of. So, no one is above the law. Everybody will be held accountable, and when it is their turn to be held accountable, they should not misrepresent to the public that there is any orchestration to oppress the Minority, to gag the Minority, to intimidate the Minority, and to prevent the Minority from doing their work.

Mr Speaker, on the issue of anti-corruption agencies, indeed, the issue is not that we want to gag anti-corruption agencies, but it is because agency because we are frustrated by the failure of anti-corruption agencies to hold public officers accountable for their deeds that was what activated us to call for the scrapping of some anti-corruption agencies because we felt they had failed woefully in terms of the expectations of Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, a few weeks ago, I went to play tennis, and just by the tennis court, a young man was mowing the lawn. When the ball fell outside the court, and I went to pick it, he greeted me and said, "Leader, why are all those thieves that stole this country's money still walking around in our streets? Why are all those thieves who stole this country's money and you saw it still walking in the streets and having the effrontery to be saying the things that they are saying?" I was stunned that a cleaner in a hotel would confront me so frontally, and he looked me in the face

and told me, “Leader, we voted you people so that you will fight corruption. We want you to fight corruption.”

Mr Speaker, if we do not hold each other accountable and fight corruption, there is no greater threat to democracy than failing to fight corruption. Those of us who know the history of this country, go and check the records. Anytime that a democracy has been overthrown, the first reason that the military dictatorship gives is that there was massive corruption, and they were not fighting corruption. So, fighting corruption is the surest way to sustain and preserve our democracy, in addition to delivering on social and economic goods. So, we will continue to fight corruption, and if fighting corruption is what they misinterpret as attempting to intimidate the Minority, so be it.

Mr Speaker, as for the issue about the Israeli retaliatory measures, I can assure the House that this country will stand by its citizens. If a citizen gets mistreated by a foreign country, we will retaliate. So, if Israel has mistreated a Ghanaian, Ghana will retaliate, and that is what has happened, and I can assure the House that following our retaliatory measure, the situation has changed, and Israel is now treating our citizens with the kind of respect that they deserve when we get to their airports.

Mr Speaker, I have tried very hard to stay away from the discussions about the question of whether or not President John Dramani Mahama will be seeking a third term mandate. President John

Dramani Mahama indicated his view on the matter in Singapore.

8:05 p.m.

I do not understand why the Opposition will be discussing the issue of a third term in Ghana every single day. Mr Speaker, I know that due to the excellent performance of President John Dramani Mahama so far, Ghanaians are asking him to seek a third term. I know that because I read on social media and I listen to conversations. Ghanaians believe that as a result of the good deeds of H. E. President John Dramani Mahama, they do not want him to leave the presidency, and they believe that a third term is possible, and are demanding for a third term. But President John Dramani Mahama has not given any indication that he wants to go for a third term.

But I have always said that Ghanaians will be the ultimate deciders of the future of this country. Mr Speaker, why do I say that? Please pay attention. The opposition leaders of La Côte d’Ivoire came to me when I was in the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) Parliament and complained that the president there wanted to go for a third term. And they were calling on us in West Africa to support them to oppose and prevent the president from going for a third term.

So, I asked them that is the president who is seeking for a third term going to put a ballot box in front of the citizens and ask them to vote for him to go for a third term, or is he going to wake up early morning and announce that he is

continuing for a third term? They said there will be an election to determine whether or not he should go for a third term. I said that they should go and fight him at that election. That is why I say that ultimately, it will be the Constitution, institutions and the citizens of Ghana that would determine the future of our country.

Mr Speaker, your guidance and leadership have ensured that our legislative process, though often cumbersome, were conducted within the bounds of parliamentary decorum and democratic responsibility. Why are they afraid of a third term? *[Uproar]* Mr Speaker, even without a third term, look at how we have reduced their numbers. Although the House encountered a low momentum during the debate on the Budget Statement for 2026, following the ruling of the Tamale High Court that called for the re-run of the Kpandai parliamentary election, the House was able to restore order through your seamless leadership. The subsequent decision of the Supreme Court to halt the re-run, which was ordered by the Tamale High Court, reaffirms the strength of our constitutional order, the independence of the Judiciary, and the rule of law.

As legislators, we must continue to support reforms that strengthen electoral integrity and deepen public confidence in our democracy. I will also take the opportunity to commend the Hon Minority Leader and Colleagues in Leadership for their cooperation and collaboration in ensuring that Government Business was conducted diligently. To the Clerk to Parliament and the staff of the Parliamentary Service, I

thank them for always being there to provide the needed technical support and assistance in the discharge of our mandate.

Mr Speaker, this Third Meeting, which commenced on the 21st October, 2025, comes to a close today, 19th December, 2025. The House had 35 Sittings within a nine-week period. During this Meeting, the House considered the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of Government of Ghana, which is one of the most important Businesses that we conducted during this Meeting.

In pursuance of our financial oversight Mandate, the House took the Budget Statement and Economic Policy through rigorous debates and scrutiny, leading to the adoption of the Estimates for the various Ministries in record time. The timely adoption of the Estimates from the various Ministries saw the Appropriation (No.2) Bill, 2025 passed. The successful passage of the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of Government stands as a testament to Parliament's constitutional duty to scrutinise, debate, and approve policies aimed at stabilising the economy, promoting growth, and safeguarding the welfare of the Ghanaian people. The Budget reflects difficult but necessary choices shaped by prevailing domestic and global economic realities, and guided by our collective resolve to place Ghana on a sustainable path of recovery and development.

Aside, the 2026 Budget Statement and financial policy of government, the House passed a number of legislation

and undertook various Businesses during this Meeting. One remarkable legislation that was passed by this House in fulfilment of the campaign promises of the great National Democratic Congress (NDC) party was the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Act, 2025, which was subsequently assented to by His Excellency the President on 10th December, 2025.

This is a testament to the responsible and prudent governance that we promise the good people of this noble country. These actions underscore Parliament's responsiveness to public concerns, economic pressures on households and businesses, and the need to recalibrate our fiscal framework in line with current socio-economic conditions. While revenue mobilisation remains critical, this House has demonstrated that taxation must always be balanced with equity, fairness, and the capacity of citizens to endure.

Other legislation includes The Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology, Kumasi, Bill, 2025, which we considered and passed, the COVID-19 Health Recovery Levy (Repeal) Bill, 2025, Value Added Tax Bill, 2025, Virtual Assets Service Providers Bill, 2025, Ghana Education Trust Fund (Amendment) Bill, 2025 all of which we passed, 24-Hour Economy Authority Bill, 2025, Governance Advisory Council Bill, Interstate Succession Bill, 2025 and Legal Education Reform Bill, 2025 all of which are at the Committee stage; Petroleum Revenue Management (Amendment) Bill, Bank of Ghana

(Amendment) Bill, 2025, Road Traffic (Amendment) Bill, 2025 and Ghana Sports Fund Bill, 2025 have all been passed. Mr Speaker, we have passed so many pieces of legislation.

Now we know that our promise to the *Okada* riders that we will legalise *Okada* riding has been approved by this House, it has been passed and is now law. If the necessary administrative mechanisms are put in place, *Okada* is now legalised. The Ghana Sports Fund Bill, 2025 has been passed. When put in place, it would be a mechanism that will enable the raising and mobilisation of resources and funds for the development of sports across all sectors.

Mr Speaker, the debates and discussions during this Meeting have been without contention. However, disagreement is not a weakness of Parliament. Rather, it is the lifeblood of representative democracy.

I commend Members on both Sides of the House for their commitment, resilience, and willingness to engage constructively in the national interest, even where we disagree.

8:15 p.m.

Mr Speaker, let me repeat that this country is on the right path. The economy is doing well. Our finances are doing well. Our Minister for Finance is doing well. Our President is doing well. We have suddenly become the envy of all nations around here. Ghanaians are now very proud of their country and very proud of their Government. Wherever a

Ghanaian is, every other person that I have met has said, they are following the developments in our country, and our country is doing well. *[Hear! Hear!]* This is neither a moment for complacency nor for self-congratulation alone. Rather, it is a moment for sober reflection, acknowledgement of collective effort, and renewed commitment to our national development agenda.

We inherited an economy burdened by deep-rooted structural weaknesses, reckless fiscal management, corruption, and a severe erosion of both public and investor confidence. Through decisive leadership, prudent governance, and partnership with Parliament and stakeholders, this administration has reversed the decline, stabilised the economy, restored credibility at home and abroad, and firmly placed Ghana on the path of recovery and sustainable growth.

Mr Speaker, the turnaround of our economy has been confirmed by Ghana's sovereign credit rating upgrade from CCC+ to B- by Standards and Poor's(S&P) Global Ratings and affirmed by the International Monetary Fund (IMF) in its fifth review of Ghana's 39-month extended credit facility agreement concluded in December 2025. Mr Speaker, the IMF said, and I quote:

“Microeconomic stabilisation is gaining momentum with strong growth and single-digit inflation for the first time since 2021. The fiscal and external positions have improved and good progress has been made on debt restructuring. These gains

reflect the authority's strong programme ownership, favourable external development, and improved investor confidence.”

This is what the World Bank and the IMF are saying about Ghana. The successes we celebrate today are also a testament to the unwavering commitment of Parliament. Through our resilience, diligence, and constructive engagement, we have transformed policies into tangible progress, ensured that every initiative contributes meaningfully to national development, and strengthened the foundation of our democracy. Mr Speaker, the key achievements of this House have been to support the Government to ensure macroeconomic stability. Inflation, which was as high as 54 per cent, is now at 6.3 per cent. There is improved national currency performance. The Ghana cedi is stronger against the US dollar now than it has been for many years. We have improved public debt management.

Mr Speaker, the debt, which was GH¢722 billion, has been reduced to GH¢685 billion. Mr Speaker, we have an improved lending environment. As we speak, banks are lending at far lower rates than they were lending. We have improved and strengthened the economic indicators. Gross Domestic Product (GDP) growth, international reserves, import cover, and sectoral performance have all shown significant improvement, demonstrating the resilience and effectiveness of our economic strategy. These achievements reflect a clear trajectory towards sustainable growth,

microeconomic stability, and financial resilience.

Mr Speaker, I now wish to highlight some of the key promises made by President John Dramani Mahama to Ghanaians upon assuming office and the progress achieved in fulfilling them. We scrapped the e-Levy, the COVID-19 levy, the 10 per cent levy on winnings, the Emissions levy, and import duty on vehicles and equipment for industrial agricultural purposes. The Big Push policy for strategic infrastructure development was launched — so much money, billions of cedis given, social intervention such as no academic fees policy for first-year tertiary institutions implemented, no fee stress implemented, and free tertiary education for persons with disability implemented. The Ghana Medical Cares Trust Fund, Mahama Cares implemented, free sanitary pads all implemented, 24-Hour Economy is working, allocations are made for the Women's Development Bank, and the National Apprenticeship Programme is happening. Digital initiatives such as the One Million Coders Programme is ongoing, the Agricultural Economic Transformation Agenda and the Feed Ghana programme are ongoing. The establishment of GoldBod is very successful, and it has helped to strengthen the cedi against the dollar.

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, as we approach the Christmas break, let us take pride in these collective achievements led by President John Dramani Mahama and celebrate the resilience and unity of Ghanaians. These milestones are not mere statistics; they are the product of

dedication, shared responsibility, and collective action. The future is bright, the path is clear, and together we will continue to build a Ghana of sustainable growth, prosperity, and dignity for all.

Mr Speaker, at this very important juncture, in this Chamber, Bawku Central and the issues in Bawku were mentioned. I have kept quiet, and I did not say anything, and I said that and I acted that way for a very good reason. The conflict in Bawku, which is about chieftaincy and who is the rightful chief of the place, was a matter that came up as far back as 2021. It resulted in a lot of violence, many people died, and President Akufo-Addo referred the matter to His Royal Majesty the Otumfuo, to deal with. Because the Otumfuo was dealing with the matter, I decided never to comment on that matter. Because commenting on it would have undermined the authority, the dignity, and the majesty of Otumfuo.

So, in spite of all the provocation and the things that were said in this Chamber, I kept quiet and said nothing about it. I now want to report to you that His Royal Majesty Otumfuo presented his report to H.E. the President. He concluded that the rightful chief of Bawku and the Kusasi traditional area is the Zuguran Asigri Abugrago Azorka II, and he made further recommendations that we hope, if implemented, will bring peace, bring law and order, and ensure the security of lives and property in the Bawku area.

Mr Speaker, I stayed away from the Constituency for very good reasons, and I can assure Members that we are all

trying very hard to deal with a very delicate matter. Many of us in this Chamber, do not understand, but I have tried very hard to maintain my cool in the face of extreme provocation. I want to assure Members that no matter what they say and no matter what they do, I, Mahama Ayariga, will never be provoked.

I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.
[Hear! Hear!]

8:25 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, can we listen to the concluding remark of the Speaker in silence?

Hon Members, this is the remark of Rt Hon Alban Sumana Kingsford Bagbin, Speaker of the Parliament of the Republic of Ghana, at the end of the Third Meeting of the First Session of the Ninth Parliament of the Republic of Ghana. I will therefore present same in a representative capacity.

Hon Members, as the book of Ecclesiastes reminds us, there is a time for everything: a time to commence and a time to close, a time for sitting and a time to rise, a time for debates and a time for recess. Today, the time has come for us to bring Sittings of the Third Meeting of the First Session of the Ninth Parliament to an end and to rise to adjourn *sine die*, to a recess. A recess to focus on other responsibilities and duties of Members of Parliament. As we reflect on our deliberations and accomplishments over the past weeks, we once again express our collective gratitude to

the Almighty God for bestowing on us the wisdom, strength, tolerance and spirit of cooperation that guided our deliberations.

Hon Members, despite a few challenges, this House successfully transacted significant legislative oversight and representational Business during the Meeting, reflecting our shared commitment to democratic governance, good order and national development. Over 35 Sittings of the Meeting, the House recomposed its Standing and Select Committees, approved the President's nomination of Justice Paul Baffoe-Bonnie as Chief Justice of the Republic of Ghana; considered 14 Bills and passed 7; examined and brought into force several legislative instruments; received and debated Ministerial and Members' Statements; answered over 100 Questions; approved Petroleum and Contracts Agreement, Tax and Visa Waivers, Headquarters Agreement and International Conventions; approved the 2026 Disbursement Formula for Key Statutory Funds; and referred several Reports and Policy Papers to appropriate Committees.

Hon Members, one of the key highlights of the Meeting was the presentation of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government for the 2026 Financial Year to Parliament on Thursday, 13th November, 2025 by the Hon Minister for Finance. Subsequently, I led the Leadership of the House in collaboration with the Parliamentary Training Institute to organise a Post-Budget Workshop for Hon Members and selected staff of Parliamentary Service to

deepen understanding of the policies, assumptions and rationale underpinning the Budget. I commend Leadership, Hon Members, the Clerk-to-Parliament and the Parliamentary Training Institute for their respective roles in ensuring the success of the workshop.

Hon Members, beyond the core Business of the House, Parliament continued to engage actively in the International Parliamentary Forum to strengthen parliamentary diplomacy. During the Meeting, Parliament successfully hosted the 9th Biennial General Meeting of the African Parliamentary Network Against Corruption (APNAC), during which I had the honour to be elected President of APNAC. I was further elected President of African Geopolitical Group of the Inter-Parliamentary Union, IPU, as well as appointed a member of the IPU Task Force to mediate the Russian-Ukraine War. These recognitions affirm the confidence and trust reposed in Ghana's parliamentary democracy by the international community, a reputation we must continue to uphold and protect zealously.

Hon Members, capacity building and mentorship initiatives featured prominently during the Meeting. The Legislative Management Service area of the Parliamentary Service organised the maiden, Practice and Procedure Week, aimed at highlighting parliamentary practice and procedure as the driving force of parliamentary Business and deepening the understanding of Members and Staff. In addition, I initiated the maiden *Time with the Speaker Series* to engage first-time

Members of Parliament in a less formal setting to promote mentorship, dialogue and shared understanding outside the rigid procedural environment of the Chamber. Feedback from this engagement was very positive and it is my hope that similar engagements will in due course be extended to other Members.

8:35 p.m.

Hon Members, while we rightly celebrate the many successes achieved during this Meeting, we must also reflect soberly on the unfortunate and chaotic scene witnessed during the debate on issues relating to the Kpandai parliamentary seat. Although protests, walkouts and uproars have become permissible features of parliamentary practice, they nevertheless need not threaten the orderly and dignified conduct of parliamentary Business. This is why I rowdily condemn the chaotic conduct of some Hon Members that day. Parliament draws part of its legitimacy and relevance from the polarity and divergence of views. Therefore, we must all endeavour to engage in rigorous debates in a dispassionate manner, devoid of conduct that has the potential to undermine the image and dignity of the House.

Let me assure you, the people of Ghana, that Parliament will continue to discharge its mandates with patriotic favour and unwavering commitment to the national interests and the welfare of the citizenry.

Before I conclude, I wish to place on record my profound appreciation to the

Hon First and Second Deputy Speakers for their steadfast support and dedication to the work of the House. Hon Members would agree with me that my two Deputies have both acquitted themselves rightly and honourably, deserving of the high respect and adoration accorded them by the Ghanaian people.

I am equally grateful to the leadership of the House, particularly the Hon Majority and Minority leaders, for their cooperation, maturity and commitment to parliamentary Business. I further commend the Clerk to Parliament, management, and all officers of the Parliamentary Service for their continued professionalism, diligence, and unwavering dedication to the work of the House, which has been instrumental in the effective functioning of Parliament. I also recognise and appreciate the Parliamentary Press Corps and our media partners for their significant roles in promoting the work of Parliament, enhancing transparency and keeping the Ghanaian public informed of the proceedings and decisions of the august House.

Finally, as we rise for Christmas recess, I extend my warmest wishes to Hon Members, management and staff of the parliamentary service and all

Ghanaians. Here is my humble prayer for Hon Members: may we, as representatives of the people, be awakened to our God-given duty to exert justice, defend the rights of the poor and the needy and give Ghana the progress that it desperately needs. May Christ strengthen Hon Members with integrity and character to act righteously and not out of selfish ambition. May he protect Hon Members and Ghanaians from all evil powers that prowl around the world seeking to destroy mankind during this festive season. May the good Lord grant Hon Members abundant wisdom to know his directives for leaders, namely to labour for the good of creation and the welfare of those Ghanaians, and his daily prayer is to get bread even if without butter.

During this hallowed season, may God bless our homeland Ghana and make our nation great and strong. I wish all Hon Members and staff a Merry Christmas, and a prosperous and happy New Year.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned sine die at 8:45 p.m.

Editor's Note

This *Official Report* was corrected by the House on 10th February, 2026.